

Rostas

Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

July 2026

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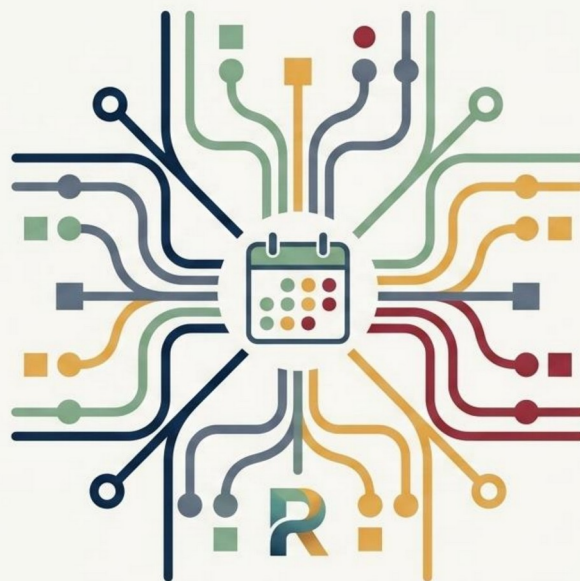
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Quick Start Guide — Orchestrating with Empathy

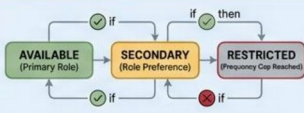
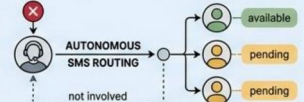
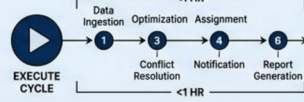
Orchestrating with Empathy

The Rostas Playbook for
Coordinators at Knox
Church Waitara
May 2026



NotebookLM

Transitioning from static scheduling to a dynamic engine

Legacy Manual Systems	The Rostas Engine
 Flat Availability: Volunteers are treated as a simple 'yes' or 'no'.	 Granular Logic: Utilizes three availability states, primary/secondary role preferences, and strict frequency caps.
 Coordinator Intervention: Cancellations require the coordinator to act as a middleman, sending emails and making phone calls to find replacements.	 Automated Autonomy: Cancellations trigger an autonomous SMS replacement chain that routes around the coordinator directly to available backups.
 Vulnerable to Burnout: Relies heavily on the same few volunteers, often leading to quiet resignations.	 Protected Energy: The engine enforces monthly limits and tracks historical scheduling to ensure fair rotation.
 High Administrative Load: A single roster cycle requires two to three hours of manual data entry and cross-referencing.	 Orchestrated Efficiency: A full cycle is reduced to under an hour through a six-step, single-button workflow.

NotebookLM

System access is purposefully distilled to protect data integrity

	Roster Coordinator	Overall Coordinator	Tech Support
Sync roster types	✓	✓	✓
View/Edit volunteer data	✓	✓	✓
Build/Edit rosters	✓	✓	✓
Manage Replacements	✓	✓	✓
Sync volunteers from Infoodle		✓	✓
Add new volunteers/roster types		✓	✓
Apps Script / Technical changes			✓

Note: Infoodle remains the ultimate source of truth. Name changes and new volunteer additions must be processed in Infoodle before syncing to Rostas.

NotebookLM

The roster follows a strict, sequential seven-step sequence



NotebookLM

Step 0 & 1 establish a synchronised foundation before processing availability

Step 0: Refresh the Seasons Calendar

0. Refresh calendar

Function: Recalculates all roster dates and overlays New Zealand public and school holidays.



Rule: This must be run after editing any season start or end dates, or at the exact beginning of a new roster cycle.

Step 1: Sync Volunteers from Infoodle

1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle

Function: Pulls fresh volunteer data and group memberships. (Runs automatically at 2:00 AM daily, but can be triggered manually).



Warning: Rostas strictly reads from Infoodle. If a volunteer is missing, they must be added to the Infoodle database first.

NotebookLM

Step 2 captures exact role preferences to optimize assignments

Volunteers are sent a personalised link to set their preferences for the season. This prevents the system from assigning a volunteer to a role they are unqualified for or uncomfortable performing.

The Three-Tier Preference System:

- 1. **Primary Roles:** The default, preferred tasks a volunteer enjoys.
- 2. **Backup Roles:** Tasks a volunteer is capable of, but prefers not to do regularly ("Happy to fill in").
- ✖ 3. **Excluded Roles:** Tasks the volunteer cannot perform. The engine will strictly ignore these candidates for these roles.

Coordinators can also manually set these preferences via the editable 'Preferred Roles' list in the Rostas desktop view for volunteers who do not use the web link.



NotebookLM

Frequency caps strictly protect volunteer energy and prevent burnout

Frequency settings control the maximum number of times per month a volunteer can be rostered for a specific roster type.

- The defaults are set to 4 for weekly rosters and 2 for fortnightly rosters.
- Coordinators can adjust this downward in the 'Volunteer Details' view for individuals needing a lighter load.
- Notes can be added to clarify specific arrangements (e.g., "4th Monday only").

Max Days Rostered

1 2 3 **4** Days Per Month



Insight

The Engine Rule: The automated system strictly enforces this monthly maximum. Once a cap is reached, the system will actively bypass the volunteer for the remainder of the month, even if they have explicitly marked themselves as "Available" for those dates.

NotebookLM

Step 3 gathers precise availability via a three-state selection process

Volunteers receive a personalised availability link. Everything defaults to "Available" — volunteers only need to interact with dates they cannot make.

✓
Available

?
Unsure

✗
Can't make it

The Automated Nudge Protocol:

1. Send: Availability emails are dispatched via the Run Commands dashboard.

2. Wait: The system waits the configured duration (default: 2 days).

3. Evaluate: A daily background process identifies non-responders.

4. Nudge: An SMS reminder with a direct link is sent automatically.

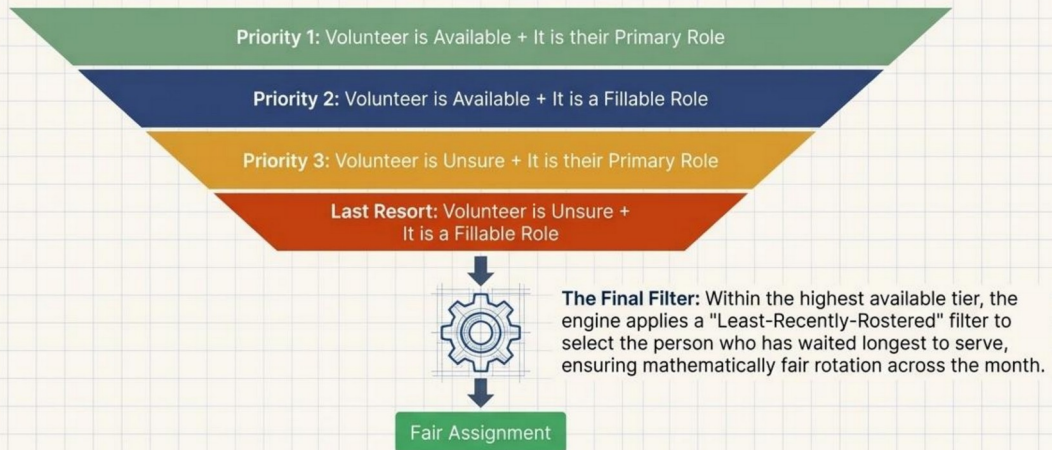


This fires exactly once per cycle to respect the volunteer's inbox. Opted-out volunteers are silently skipped.

NotebookLM

The Roster Engine logic synthesizes availability, preferences, and history

When Step 4 ("Build Roster") is triggered, the system does not fill slots blindly. It filters every volunteer through a strict four-tier priority matrix:



NotebookLM

Step 4 & 5 require auditing the output via the Traffic Light UI

Rostas builds the next 8 weeks of dates by default. Before proceeding, coordinators must inspect the Global Roster view.

Step 4 Audit: Global Roster Day view

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
1 Mon 18, 3AM-12PM	2 Mon 19, 1PM-4PM	3	4	5	6	7
18	19 Tue 19, 10AM-1PM	20	21 Thu 21, 10AM-1PM	12 Fri 22, 2PM-5PM	13	17
18	19 Tue 19, 1PM-4PM	20 Wed 20, 3PM-6PM	21	22 Fri 22, 2PM-5PM	23 Sat 23, 11AM-2PM	24 Sun 24, 3AM-12PM
25	26	27	28	29	30	1

The Status Indicators:

- Green (Filled):** A solid assignment.
- Amber (Pending):** An assignment where the volunteer marked themselves 'Unsure'.
- Red (Unfilled):** The engine could not find an available volunteer. These require manual coordinator intervention to locate a substitute or adjust role requirements.

Step 5 Preview: Comms Dashboard



Step 5 (Preview Communications):

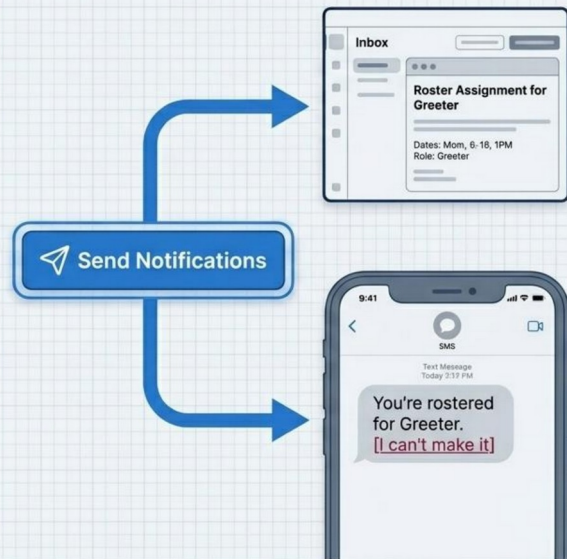
Utilize the Comms Dashboard to preview the exact wording, dates, and layouts of all pending emails and SMS notifications before dispatching them.

NotebookLM

Step 6 dispatches all confirmed assignments instantly

With a single tap on "Send Notifications" in the Run Commands view, Rostas dispatches assignments to every volunteer with a Filled or Pending status.

- The volunteer receives an email detailing their role and dates.
- A corresponding SMS is sent simultaneously.
- Pending volunteers receive explicit "Yes, I can make it" and "Can't make it" confirmation buttons to lock in their status.
- All communications include a "Can't make it" fail-safe link to handle unexpected changes.

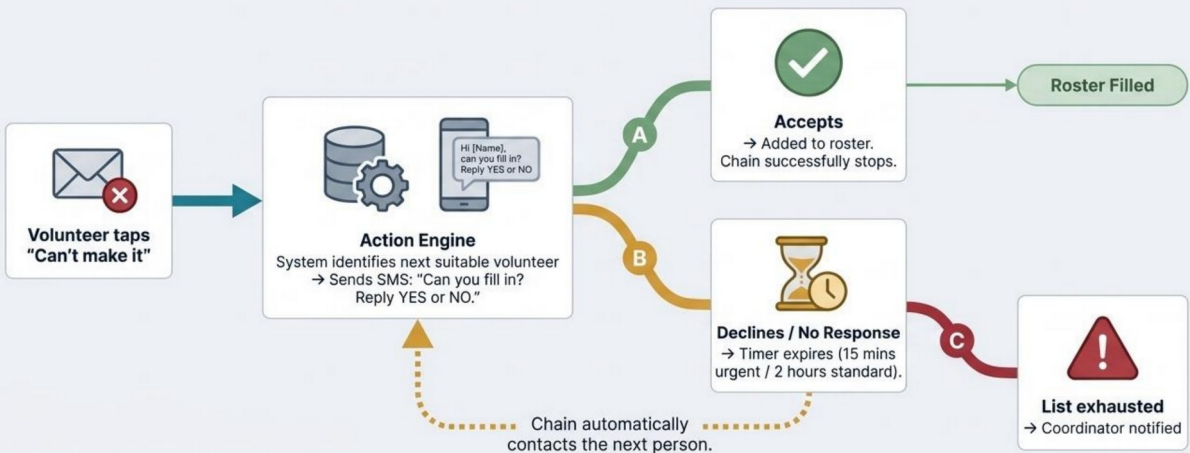


NotebookLM

The automated SMS chain executes stress-free replacements

When a volunteer taps 'Can't make it', the coordinator is removed from the friction of finding a replacement. The system takes over immediately.

 **System Parameter:**
SMS traffic pauses automatically between 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM NZ time to respect volunteers' privacy.

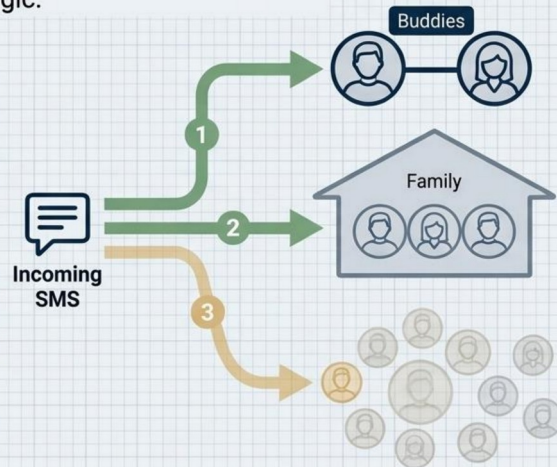


NotebookLM

Relational Rostering aligns households and preferred buddies

An advanced feature activated via the Quick Controls panel, Relational Rostering adds an empathetic secondary pass to the engine logic.

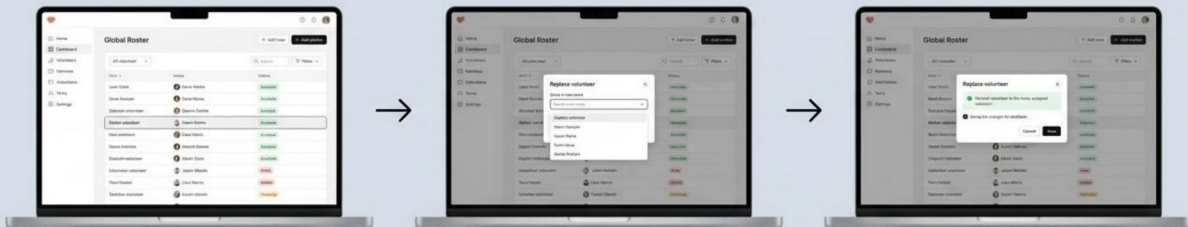
- **Household Pairing:** Parents and teenagers can be assigned to the same service dates, consolidating travel into a single car trip and simplifying family logistics.
- **Preferred Buddies:** Volunteers who prefer to work alongside a specific partner are paired together to increase retention and comfort.
- **Warm Replacements:** If a volunteer declines an assignment, the SMS replacement chain targets their preferred buddy or a household member first before contacting the broader candidate list.



NotebookLM

Manual interventions handle unexpected changes outside the automated loop

When a volunteer bypasses the system (e.g., phones the coordinator directly to cancel and nominates their own substitute), manual overrides are required.



1. Select

Selecting the specific roster slot in the Global Roster or Volunteer Details view.

2. Replace

Opening the 'Replace volunteer' dropdown modal to choose a specific substitute.

3. Save

Saving the changes. The new volunteer is instantly notified.

Alternative path: Select 'Save as Declined'. This marks the slot empty and intentionally hands the notification volunteer now and intentionally lands control back to the automated SMS chain to find a backup autonomously.

NotebookLM

Best Practices for Empathetic Rostering

Master the system by adhering to these four foundational rules:



1. Sync First

Always pull fresh Infoodle data and execute Step 0 upon making season changes before commanding a build.



2. Give Notice

Respect people's planning horizons by dispatching availability requests two to three weeks prior to a new season.



3. Review Before Sending

Never dispatch notifications blindly. Always audit the Global Roster for "Red" unfilled slots.



4. Trust the Chain

Resist the urge to micromanage cancellations. Allow the automated SMS system to handle sick calls and locate replacements autonomously.

Empower your volunteers. Simplify your scheduling.

NotebookLM

Fair, automatic, kind rostering for churches and volunteer organisations.

What is Rostas?

Rostas is your organisation's volunteer roster assistant. It handles the time-consuming, people-sensitive work of building rosters, collecting availability, and finding replacements when someone can't make it — automatically, fairly, and kindly.

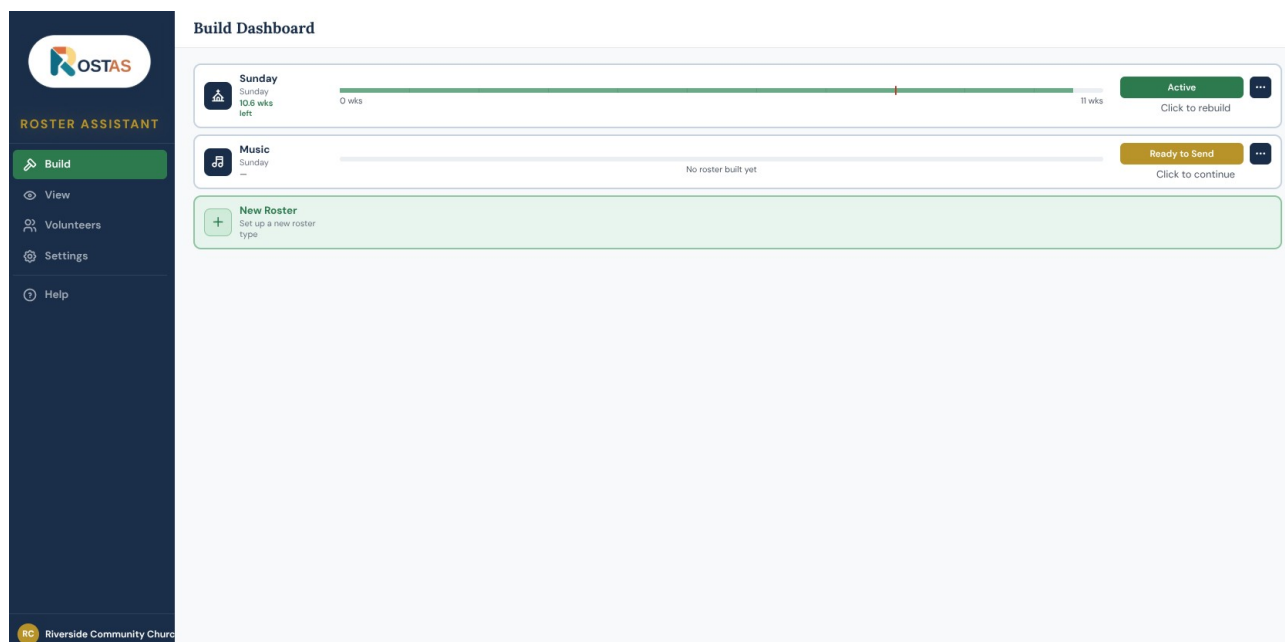
Once set up, Rostas runs most of the roster cycle on its own. Your job shifts from juggling spreadsheets and chasing people by text to simply reviewing what Rostas has prepared and pressing go.

How Rostas Works — The Big Picture

Rostas works in a rhythm that repeats every few weeks. The six-step Rebuild Wizard guides you through each stage in order:



The six-step roster lifecycle. The Rebuild Wizard guides you through each step — each stage is triggered by a single button.

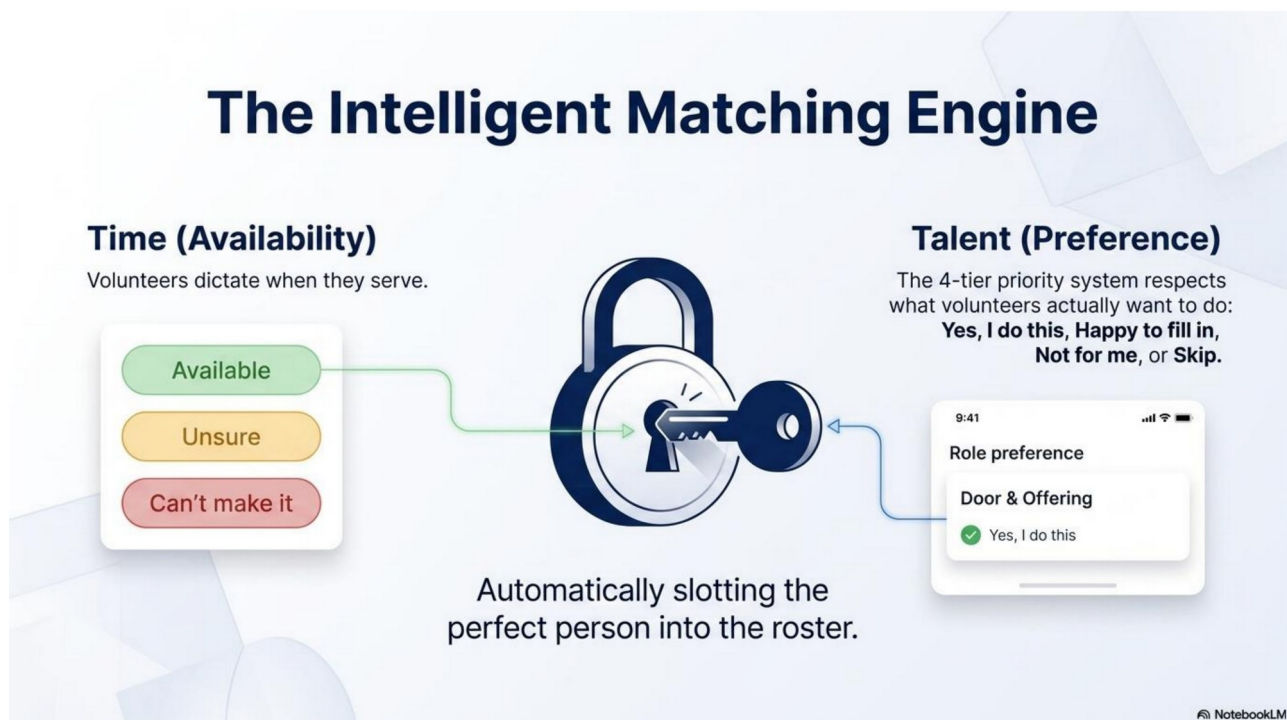


The Build Dashboard — your starting point for each roster cycle. Each card shows the current build status and coverage bar for that roster type. Click any card to open its wizard.

Key Concepts

Availability — Simple for Volunteers

Before each build, Rostas emails your volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available. Volunteers receive a personalised link — no password, no app — and see a simple calendar of dates. Everything starts as **Available** — volunteers only change the dates they can't make.



Volunteers tap their dates on a simple form. Everything defaults to Available — they only mark the dates they can't make.

If a volunteer doesn't respond, Rostas sends an automatic SMS nudge after a configurable number of days. No manual chasing needed.

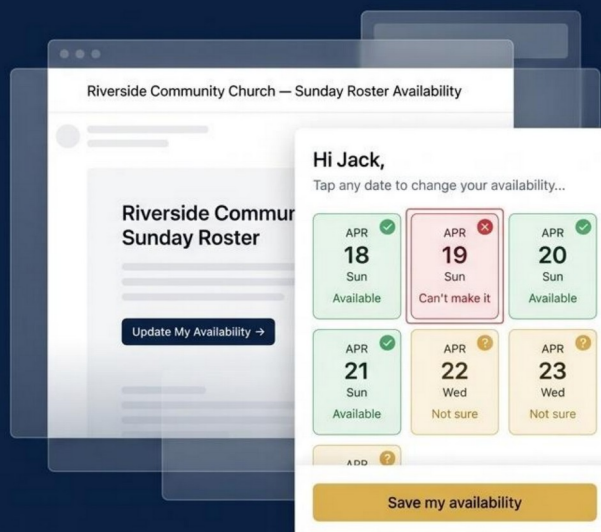
The Intelligent Matching Engine

The roster engine doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a four-tier priority system that respects both when volunteers can serve and what they actually want to do:

Frictionless Volunteer Experience

Volunteers receive a personalised link. Everything defaults to **Available**—they **only need to tap the dates** they cannot make.

- 🕒 If they forget to respond within a few days, Rostas automatically sends a configurable SMS nudge, saving the coordinator from manual follow-ups.



The engine combines availability (when volunteers can serve) with role preferences (what they want to do) to find the best person for every slot.

Within each tier, Rostas selects the volunteer who has been rostered least recently — keeping things fair automatically over time without any manual tracking.

The Roster Board

The Board is your day-to-day view of the current roster. It shows every slot, every date, and every volunteer assignment at a glance. A traffic light colour system tells you instantly what's filled, what's pending, and what needs attention.

	Baking for Morning Tea			Barista Coffee		Door & Offering		Prayer Ministry		Serving Morning Tea	
Sun 22 Aug 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 22 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 22 Aug	— Sun 22 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 22 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 22 Aug	David Chen Sun 22 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 22 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 22 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 22 Aug	Grace Kim Sun 22 Aug	
Sun 29 Aug 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 29 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 29 Aug	— Sun 29 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 29 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 29 Aug	David Chen Sun 29 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 29 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 29 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 29 Aug	James Taufa Sun 29 Aug	
Sun 5 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 5 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 5 Sep	— Sun 5 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 5 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 5 Sep	David Chen Sun 5 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 5 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 5 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 5 Sep	Grace Kim Sun 5 Sep	
Sun 12 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 12 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 12 Sep	— Sun 12 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 12 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 12 Sep	David Chen Sun 12 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 12 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 12 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 12 Sep	James Taufa Sun 12 Sep	
Sun 19 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 19 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 19 Sep	— Sun 19 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 19 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 19 Sep	David Chen Sun 19 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 19 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 19 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 19 Sep	Grace Kim Sun 19 Sep	
Sun 26 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 26 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 26 Sep	— Sun 26 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 26 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 26 Sep	David Chen Sun 26 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 26 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 26 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 26 Sep	James Taufa Sun 26 Sep	
Sun 3 Oct 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 3 Oct	Priya Sharma Sun 3 Oct	— Sun 3 Oct	Ben Nakamura Sun 3 Oct	Fiona Walsh Sun 3 Oct	David Chen Sun 3 Oct	Mark Sullivan Sun 3 Oct	Daniel Ferreira Sun 3 Oct	Chris Parata Sun 3 Oct	Grace Kim Sun 3 Oct	
Sun 10 Oct 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 10 Oct	Priya Sharma Sun 10 Oct	— Sun 10 Oct	Ben Nakamura Sun 10 Oct	Fiona Walsh Sun 10 Oct	David Chen Sun 10 Oct	Mark Sullivan Sun 10 Oct	Daniel Ferreira Sun 10 Oct	Chris Parata Sun 10 Oct	James Taufa Sun 10 Oct	

The Roster Board — dates run down the left, roles across the top. Click any cell to select it and take action. Use the roster type tabs at the top to switch between rosters.

The Automated SMS Replacement Chain

When a rostered volunteer can't make it, they tap a link in their notification email. Rostas immediately starts working through the backup list — no coordinator involvement needed.

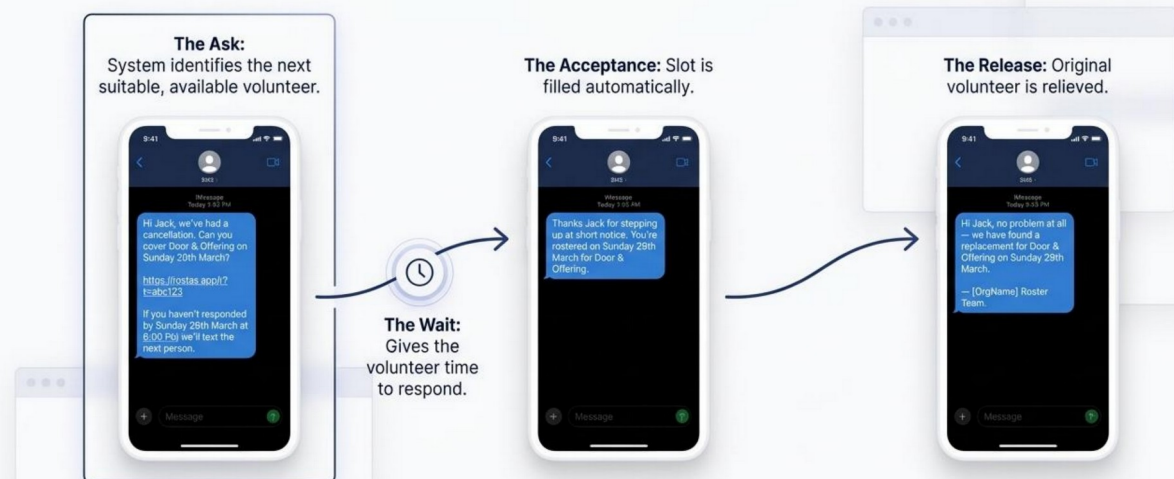
A Paradigm Shift in Coordination

	The Manual System	The Rostas Way
Time Spent	2–3 hours of individual chasing.	<1 hour via a guided, button-triggered wizard. 
Availability	Flattened 'Yes/No' guesswork.	Nuanced 3-state availability + 4-tier role preferences. 
Cancellations	Coordinator manually calls around in a panic.	Automated SMS replacement sequence (respecting configurable quiet hours). 
Retention	High risk of volunteer burnout.	Automated frequency caps and self-serve opt-outs. 

NotebookLM

Every notification includes a "Can't make it?" link. When tapped, the automated replacement engine starts — the coordinator's phone doesn't ring.

The Automated SMS Cascade



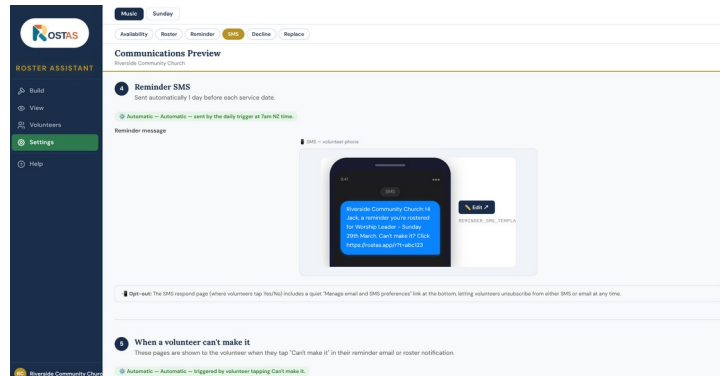
Quiet Hours Respected. SMS messages are blocked by default between 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM, holding messages in a queue so nobody is disturbed at night. 

The SMS replacement chain: Rostas texts the next suitable volunteer, waits for a reply, and keeps going until the slot is filled. The original volunteer is automatically released once a replacement accepts.

Quiet hours are always respected. Rostas never sends automated SMS during your quiet hours. If the replacement chain reaches a volunteer during that window, it pauses and resumes automatically once quiet hours end. You set the start and end times in Settings → SMS (the default is 9pm–8am).

When Rostas needs a reply by text — a replacement request, a manual-roster heads-up, or a cross-roster ask — the message contains a **4-digit code**, not a link. New Zealand mobile networks silently filter many texts that contain web links, so a tappable link in an SMS can't be relied on to arrive. On SMS a short code does double duty: it survives carrier filtering *and* it's far shorter than a link, keeping each message inside the single-text limit so your church isn't charged for two.

The volunteer opens **rostas.app/enter** and types the 4-digit code from their text. The code is single-use and expires after a short window, so it can't be reused or forwarded. Once entered, they land on the same accept / decline page they'd have reached from a link.



What a replacement request looks like on a volunteer's phone — a clear message with a 4-digit code to enter at rostas.app/enter. There's no link in the text: NZ networks filter many link-bearing SMS, and a code keeps the message short and reliable.

The rostas.app/enter page — the volunteer types the 4-digit code from their text and taps Continue, reaching the same accept / decline page a link would have opened.

Email is unchanged. Email notifications aren't filtered and aren't charged per character, so they still contain ordinary tappable links — only SMS moved to codes. Because the email carries the link and explains the entry page, it's how most volunteers first learn where rostas.app/enter is. They can bookmark it, and your church can link to it from your website behind the Rostas logo so it's always one tap away.

Looking After Your Volunteers

Rostas is designed with your volunteers in mind, not just your roster.

Who Does What

Rostas is designed so that most of the routine work happens automatically. Here's how responsibilities divide between you, your volunteers, and Rostas:

Rostas doesn't replace your judgement. There will be times when you want to override what Rostas has built — swap two people, add someone manually, or put a slot on hold. The Board makes all of this easy. Rostas handles the routine so you can focus on the exceptions.

Where to Start

The guide is organised into six parts. Jump to the section that matches where you are right now:

When you open Rostas for the first time, the setup wizard runs automatically. It takes about five minutes and covers the essentials — your organisation name, your contact details, and a quick SMS test to make sure everything is working before your first roster build.

The wizard runs once. After it's complete, Rostas opens directly to the Build Dashboard on every future visit.

Before you start: Your Rostas coordinator needs to have set up the system and given you the link to open it. If you don't have a link yet, ask them for it.

The Setup Wizard

The wizard has four steps shown across the top of the screen. You can see at a glance how far through you are and what's coming next.

Step 1 — Your Organisation

The first step establishes your organisation's identity. The name you enter here appears in every message sent to volunteers — availability emails, roster notifications, and SMS reminders.



Organisation
Riverside Com...



Your Details
Sarah



SMS
+64211494306



Done



Your Organisation

This name appears in every message sent to volunteers.

Organisation name *

Riverside Community Church



26 / 40

Timezone *

New Zealand



Country / calling code *

+64 — New Zealand



Website (optional)

<https://riversidechurch.org.nz>

Next →

Step 1 — enter your organisation name, timezone, and country code. The name appears in every volunteer-facing message Rostas sends.

Click **Next** → when all required fields are filled. The button stays disabled until everything is valid.

Step 2 — Your Details

Step 2 captures the primary coordinator's contact details. These are used for SMS test sends, coordinator escalation alerts when the replacement chain is exhausted, and the bottom of the coordinator app sidebar.

**Organisation**
Riverside Com...

**Your Details**
Sarah

**SMS**
+64211494306

**Done**



Your Details

Used in the top bar, test SMS sends, and coordinator alerts.

Your name *

Your email *

Your mobile *

Include your country code — e.g. +6421123456

← Back

Next →

Step 2 — enter your name, email address, and mobile number. Your mobile must include the country code.

Include your country code in the mobile number. Enter it as +6421123456, not 021123456. Without the country code SMS delivery will fail.

Step 3 — SMS Test

Before your first roster build, Rostas verifies that SMS is working. This step sends a real test message to your mobile so you can confirm everything is set up correctly.



Let's make sure SMS is working

Send a test message before your first roster build.

Your SMS connection is configured. Send a test message to confirm everything is working.

Send test SMS to

← Back

➤ Send test SMS →

Step 3 — your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 2. Tap "Send test SMS" to send a real test message to your phone.

How to complete Step 3

Your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 2. Tap **Send test SMS →** and wait for the message to arrive on your phone — usually within 30 seconds. Once received,

a green confirmation appears and the Next button enables.


Organisation
Riverside Com...


Your Details
Sarah


SMS
+64211494306


Done



**Let's make sure SMS is working**
Send a test message before your first roster build.

Your SMS connection is configured. Send a test message to confirm everything is working.

Send test SMS to

 **Message received — SMS is ready**

[← Back](#)

[Re-send test SMS](#)

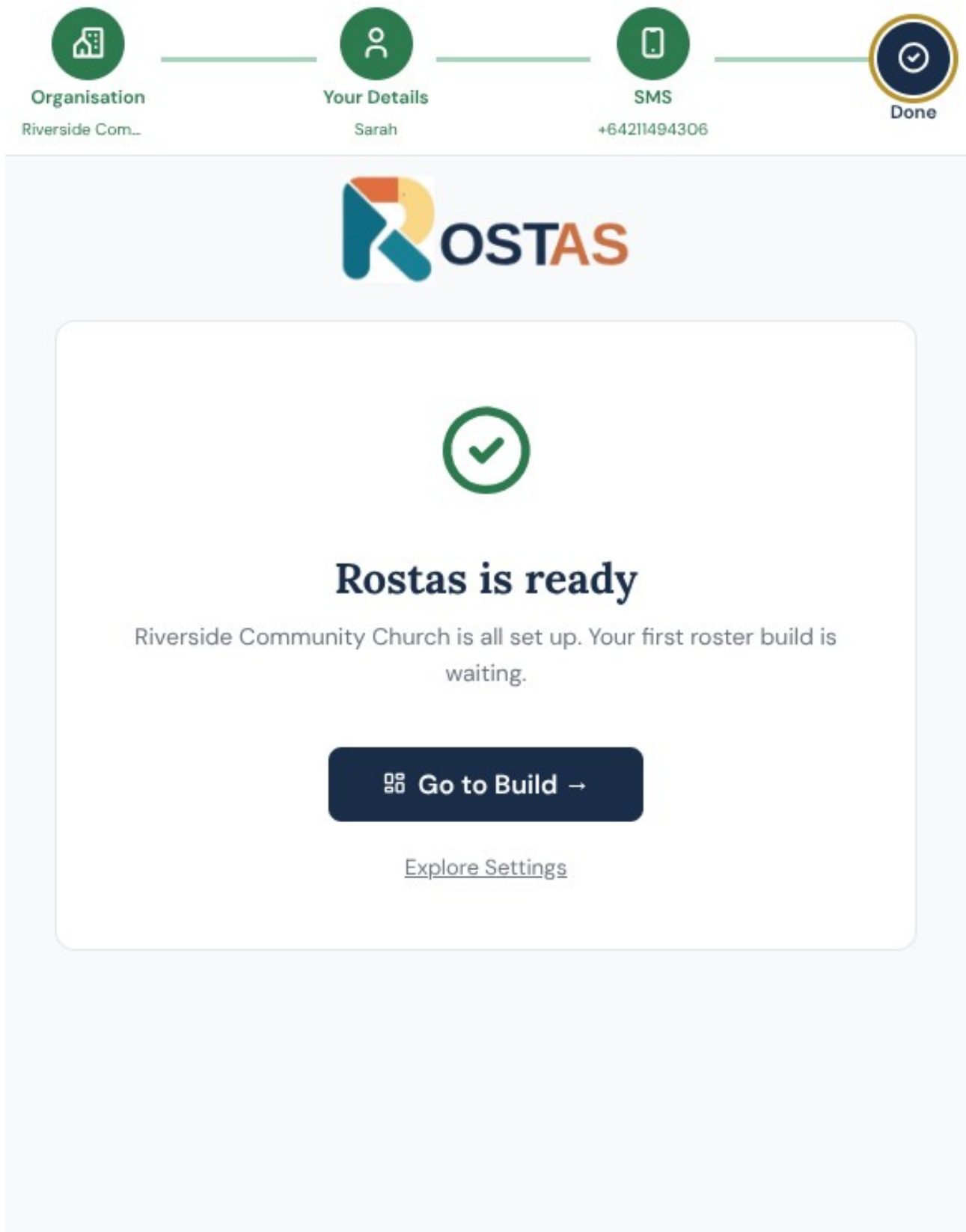
[Next →](#)

When the test message arrives, a green "Message received — SMS is ready" confirmation appears. Tap Next to continue.

If the test message doesn't arrive within a minute, check that your mobile number includes the country code and is entered correctly. You can edit the number in the field and try again. If it still fails, contact your tech support person — the SMS connection may need to be configured.

Step 4 — Done

Once SMS is confirmed, the wizard completes and Rostas is ready to use.



"Rostas is ready" — setup is complete. Click "Go to Build" to open the Build Dashboard and start your first roster cycle.

From here you have two options:

- **Go to Build →** — takes you straight to the Build Dashboard, ready to start your first roster cycle. This is the right choice if your volunteers are already imported.
- **Explore Settings** — opens the Settings view if you want to review or customise anything before your first build.

Adding Your Volunteers

Before you can build a roster, Rostas needs to know who your volunteers are. There are two ways to get them in:

Importing from CSV

If you have a spreadsheet of volunteers — from a previous roster system, a church database, or even a simple contact list — you can import them directly using the CSV Import Wizard. The wizard maps your spreadsheet columns to the right fields in Rostas and handles phone number formatting automatically.

To import volunteers from a spreadsheet

Go to **Volunteers** in the sidebar, then click **Import CSV**. The wizard walks you through uploading your file, mapping columns, and reviewing the results before importing. Phone numbers are automatically normalised to the correct international format for SMS delivery.

Your CSV needs at minimum: volunteer name and mobile number. Email address is strongly recommended so volunteers can receive roster notifications by email. Any additional columns can be mapped or skipped during the import.

Adding Volunteers Manually

To add a single volunteer, go to **Volunteers** in the sidebar and click **Add Volunteer**. Fill in their name, mobile, and email, then save. They'll appear in the volunteers list immediately and can be included in your next roster build.

What's Next

Once your volunteers are in, you're ready to build your first roster. Head to **Part C — The Roster Cycle** which walks you through the six-step wizard from start to finish.

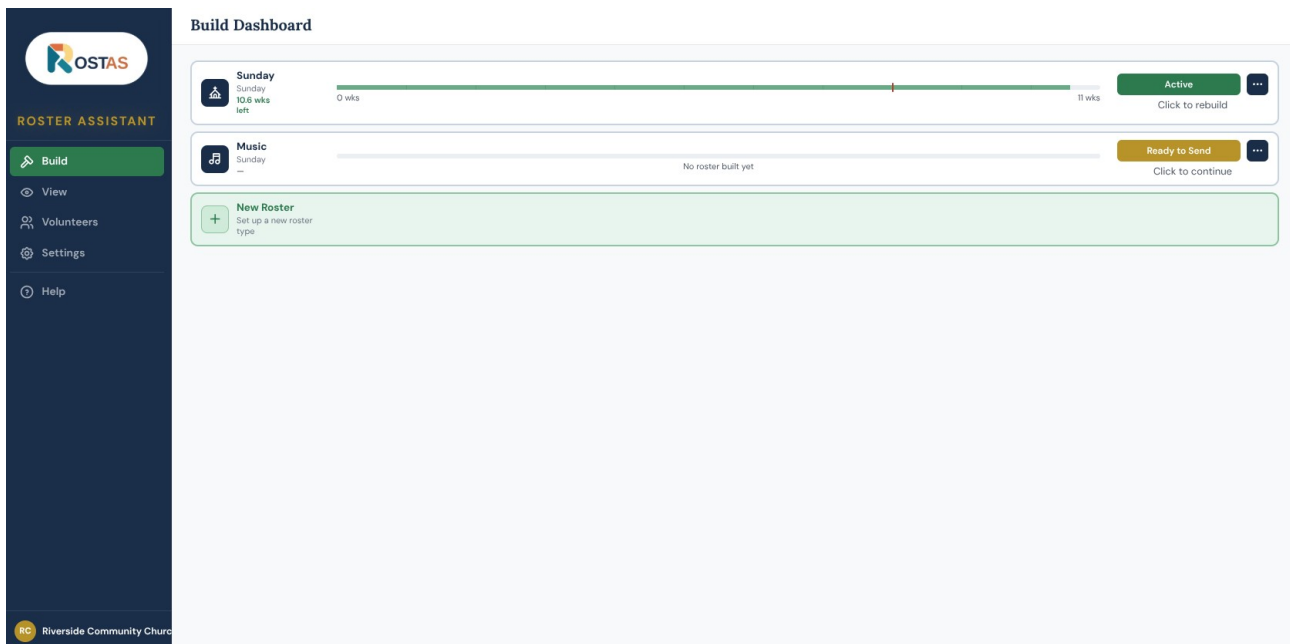
- ✓ Organisation name set
- ✓ Coordinator contact details set
- ✓ SMS test confirmed working
- ✓ Volunteers imported or added
- ○ Volunteer role preferences set (can be done during the wizard)

There are two roster wizards in Rostas. The **New Roster Wizard** runs once when you set up a new roster type — it defines the name, roles, season dates, and volunteers. The **Rebuild Wizard** runs every few weeks to collect availability, build the roster, and send notifications to volunteers.

Both start from the **Build Dashboard**.

The Build Dashboard

The Build Dashboard is your home base for all roster activity. Open it by clicking **Build** in the sidebar. It shows every active roster type with its current status and coverage bar at a glance.



The Build Dashboard — each card shows a roster type, its coverage bar (green filled, red unfilled), and current status badge. Click any card to open the wizard for that roster.

New Roster — a card at the bottom of the dashboard lets you set up a brand new roster type from scratch. See the New Roster Wizard section below.

The New Roster Wizard

Run this wizard when you're setting up a roster type for the first time — for example, adding a Music roster or a Hospitality team. It takes about 10 minutes and walks you through five steps: Name & Icon, Roles, Season, Volunteers, and Review.

You only run the New Roster Wizard once per roster type. After setup is complete, all future roster builds use the Rebuild Wizard instead.

Step 1 — Name & Icon

Give your roster a short name and choose an icon. The name appears in SMS messages, emails, and the coordinator app — keep it brief and clear.

Step 1 — name your roster. This name appears in all volunteer communications, so keep it short and recognisable — e.g. "Sunday", "Music", "Hospitality".

New Roster Step 1 of 5

Next: Add Roles --

Name your roster
Give your new roster a short name. It will appear in tables, SMS messages, and emails.

Lock Up

7 / 20

Choose an icon
Pick an icon for your roster. You can change this later.

Next: Add Roles --

After naming the roster, choose an icon that represents it. The icon appears on the Build Dashboard card and in the coordinator app sidebar tabs.

Step 2 — Roles

Define the roles that need to be filled each time this roster runs. For each role, set a minimum and maximum number of people required.

New Roster Step 2 of 5

-- Back Next: Season Setup --

Define roles for Lock Up
Add the roles volunteers will fill in this roster. The order matters — the engine fills roles from top to bottom, so put your most important role first.

Min — the minimum number of people required for this role. The roster will be flagged incomplete if this isn't met. Max — the most people you want doing this role. Using fewer here leaves more volunteers available for other roles.

	MIN	MAX
Lock Back Gate & Building	1	1

+ Add another role

-- Back Next: Season Setup --

Step 2 — add the roles for this roster. Set minimum and maximum people for each role. The engine will always try to fill the minimum; it won't exceed the maximum.

Role names matter. Use clear, specific names that volunteers will recognise — e.g. "Sound Desk", "Welcome Team", "Data Projection". These names appear in SMS messages and emails sent to volunteers.

Step 3 — Season

A season defines the date range, frequency, and day of week for this roster. Rostas uses seasons to calculate which dates to roster for, and to overlay public and school holidays automatically.

Step 3 — set up your first season. Choose day of week, frequency, and date range. Projected dates appear as pills below — school holidays are labelled automatically so you can see which dates will be paused.

Step 4 — Volunteers

Select which volunteers from your list will serve on this roster. Tick each volunteer you want to include. Only volunteers already in Rostas appear here — if someone is missing, add them in the Volunteers section first then return to this step.

Step 4 — tick each volunteer who serves in this roster. Use the search field to find someone quickly if you have a large list. You can also import additional volunteers via CSV from this step.

Step 5 — Review

The final step shows a summary of everything you've set up — roster name, icon, roles, season dates, and volunteer count. Review it carefully before confirming.

Step 5 — review your roster setup before confirming. You can go back to any previous step to make changes. Once confirmed, the roster appears on the Build Dashboard.

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Managing Roles

After a roster is created, you can add, edit, rename, or deactivate its roles at any time using the Manage Roles screen. Access it from the roster card on the Build Dashboard — click the **⋮** menu on any card and choose **Manage Roles**.

OSTAS

ROSTER ASSISTANT

Build

View

Volunteers

Settings

Help

Roles — Sunday Save

Roles for Sunday

- **Rename** — applies from your next roster build. Already-built roster dates keep their original wording.
- **Headcount & Active/Inactive** changes apply from your next roster build onward — nothing already built changes.
- **Adding a role** also applies from your next roster build onward.

ROLE	HEADCOUNT		ACTIVE / INACTIVE
	MIN	MAX	
Baking for Morning Tea	3	3	☒ Active
Barista Coffee	1	1	☒ Active
Door & Offering	2	2	☒ Active
Prayer Ministry	2	2	☒ Active
Serving Morning Tea	2	2	☒ Active

[+ Add a role](#)

RC Riverside Community Church

The Manage Roles screen — all roles for the selected roster type in one place. Set minimum and maximum people per role, and use the active toggle to temporarily suspend a role without deleting it.

Role names in SMS messages. If you rename a role, any SMS and email messages sent after that point will use the new name. Volunteers who received earlier messages with the old name may be briefly confused — consider the timing if mid-cycle.

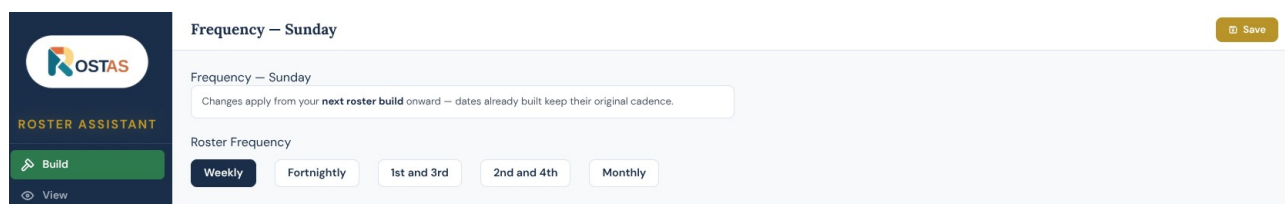
Deactivate rather than delete. Deactivating a role preserves all the history of who served in it. Deleting a role is permanent and removes that data. Unless you're correcting a setup mistake, always deactivate.

Frequency Settings

Rostas has two separate but related frequency concepts — how often a *roster* runs, and how often an individual *volunteer* gets assigned. It's worth understanding both.

Roster cadence — how often the roster runs

Not every roster runs every week. A community meal might run fortnightly, a kids' ministry only on the 1st and 3rd Sunday of the month, or a small group monthly. The **Frequency** screen sets this cadence for each roster type — it controls which dates appear in the season and therefore which dates Rostas builds for.

The screenshot shows the 'Frequency — Sunday' settings page in the Rostas application. On the left is a dark sidebar with the ROSTAS logo and 'ROSTER ASSISTANT' text, along with 'Build' and 'View' buttons. The main content area has a title 'Frequency — Sunday' and a 'Save' button in the top right. Below the title is a text box stating 'Changes apply from your next roster build onward — dates already built keep their original cadence.' Underneath is a 'Roster Frequency' section with five buttons: 'Weekly' (selected), 'Fortnightly', '1st and 3rd', '2nd and 4th', and 'Monthly'.

The Frequency screen — choose how often this roster runs. Changes apply from the next roster build onward; dates already built keep their original cadence. Access it from Build Dashboard → ... → Frequency.

Roster cadence is set once per roster type and applies to everyone in that roster. If two different groups within the same organisation run on different weeks, set them up as separate roster types.

Volunteer frequency cap — how often a volunteer gets assigned

Separate from the roster cadence, each volunteer has an individual frequency cap that controls how often they personally get rostered within a running roster. This protects volunteers from being assigned every single week even when they're always available — spreading the load fairly across the team.

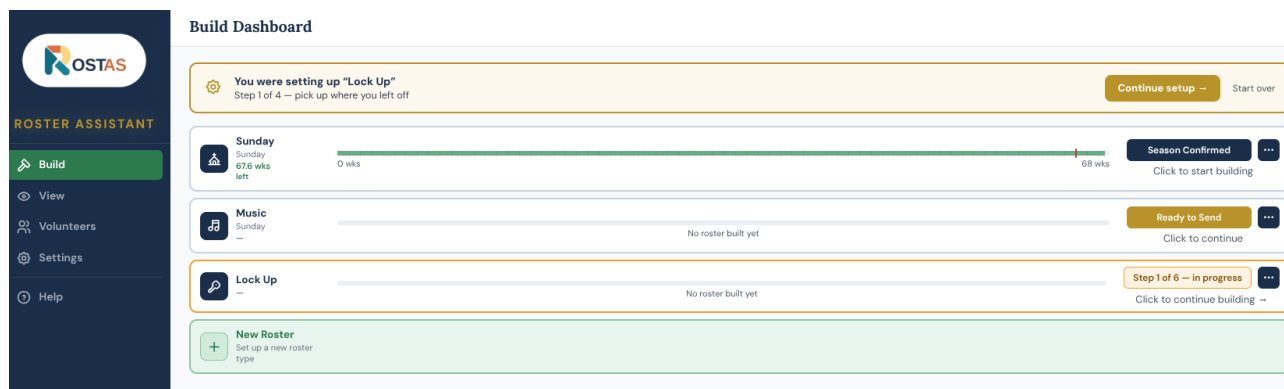
Frequency caps are set on the **volunteer detail page** under the Frequency section for each roster type. A volunteer's cap can be set independently for each roster they serve in.

The cap counts distinct service dates, not individual role assignments. A volunteer rostered to two roles on the same date counts as one service — so serving in two roles on one Sunday doesn't consume double their allocation.

The Rebuild Wizard

The Rebuild Wizard is the recurring roster cycle you run every few weeks. It collects availability from volunteers, builds the roster automatically, lets you review it, and sends notifications — all in six guided steps.

To start, click any roster card on the Build Dashboard. If a build is already in progress, you'll be taken straight to where you left off.



When a build is in progress, the dashboard card shows an amber border and a resume banner at the top of the page. Click the card to pick up where you left off.

Step 1 — Refresh & Sync

The first step refreshes your seasons calendar — overlaying public and school holidays — and confirms your volunteer list is current. This takes about 30 seconds and happens automatically when you start.

Always run this step at the start of each new cycle. It ensures your dates are correct before availability emails go out.

Step 2 — Role Preferences

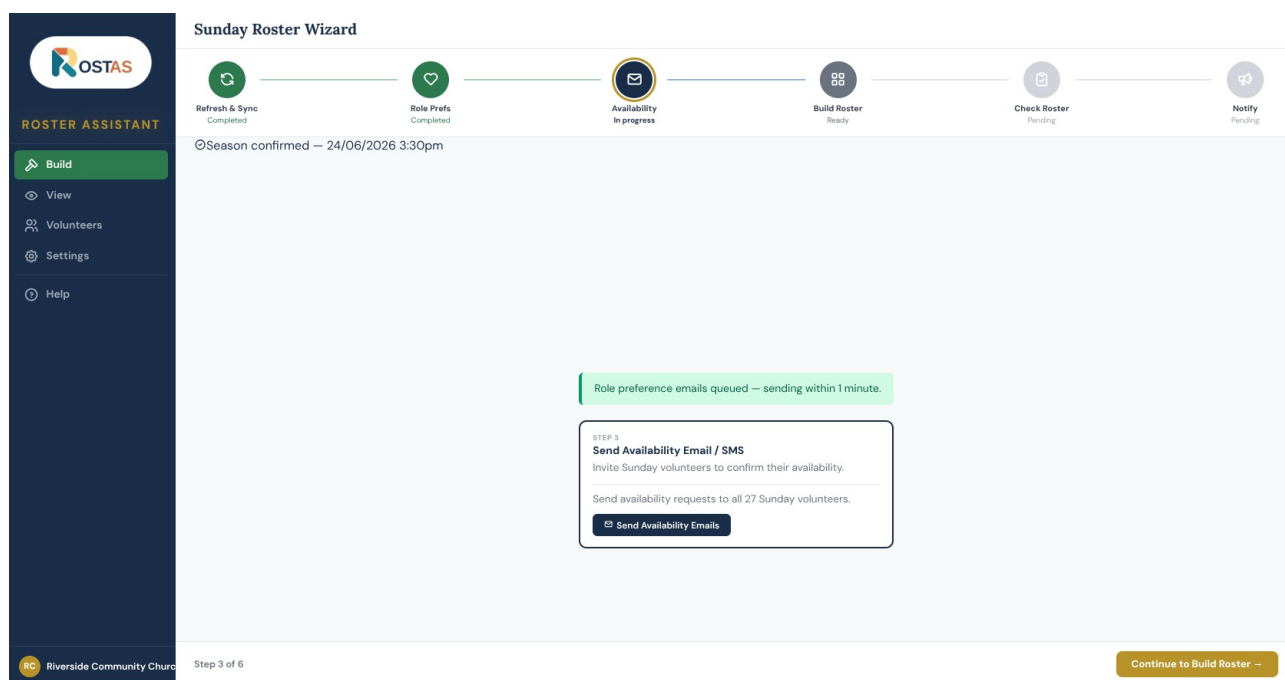
This step gives volunteers the opportunity to update their role preferences — which roles they're willing to perform. You can either send a role preference email to all volunteers, or skip this step if preferences are already up to date.

When to send role preference emails

Send them at the start of a new season, when new volunteers have joined, or when you know someone's availability for certain roles has changed. For a routine rebuild mid-season, it's usually safe to skip this step.

Step 3 — Availability

Rostas emails all active volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available. Each volunteer receives a personalised link — no login required. They tap their dates, mark any they can't make, and save.



Step 3 — click "Send Availability Emails" to notify all active volunteers. The panel updates with response stats as volunteers reply over the following days.

Allow 5-7 days for responses before moving to Step 4. Volunteers who don't respond within a configurable number of days automatically receive an SMS nudge.

Step 4 — Build Roster

With one click, the roster engine analyses every volunteer — their availability, role preferences, how recently they've served, and their monthly frequency cap — and fills every slot automatically. The build takes about 30 seconds for most rosters.

The engine uses a four-tier priority system — see Part A, The Intelligent Matching Engine for full detail on how slots are filled.

Step 5 — Check Roster

Before anything is sent to volunteers, you review what Rostas has built. Clicking **Open Roster Board** opens the Board in review mode — you can see every assignment, make any manual changes needed, and then return to the wizard. The Communications Preview tab lets you see exactly what each volunteer will receive before you send.

ROSTER ASSISTANT

Build

View

Volunteers

Settings

Help

Riverside Community Church

Sunday Roster Wizard

Season confirmed — 24/06/2026 12:11pm

Refresh & Sync
Completed

Role Prefs
Skipped

Availability
Completed

Build Roster
Completed

Check Roster
In progress

Notify
Pending

STEP 5

Check Roster & Communications

Review assignments and communications in AppSheet before notifying volunteers.

All roles filled for upcoming services

Check that all roles are filled, make any manual replacements, and preview the notification emails before sending.

Open Roster Board

Once you're happy with the roster, mark as reviewed to unlock notifications.

Reviewed — ready to notify

Step 5 of 6

Step 5 — open the Roster Board to review assignments, or use the Communications Preview to check exactly what volunteers will receive. When you're satisfied, click "Reviewed — ready to notify" to proceed.

This application was created by a Google Apps Script user

Report abuse Learn more

ROSTER ASSISTANT

Build

View

Volunteers

Settings

Help

Riverside Community Church

Sunday

Music

Sunday Roster Board

Filled

SMS Chain

Pending

Unfilled

ROSTERED TOGETHER

NOT ROSTERED TOGETHER

FREQUENCY

Once every 2 wks

Not yet rostered

Grace Kim

Baking for Morning Tea — Unfilled

Baking for Morning Tea

02/05/2027

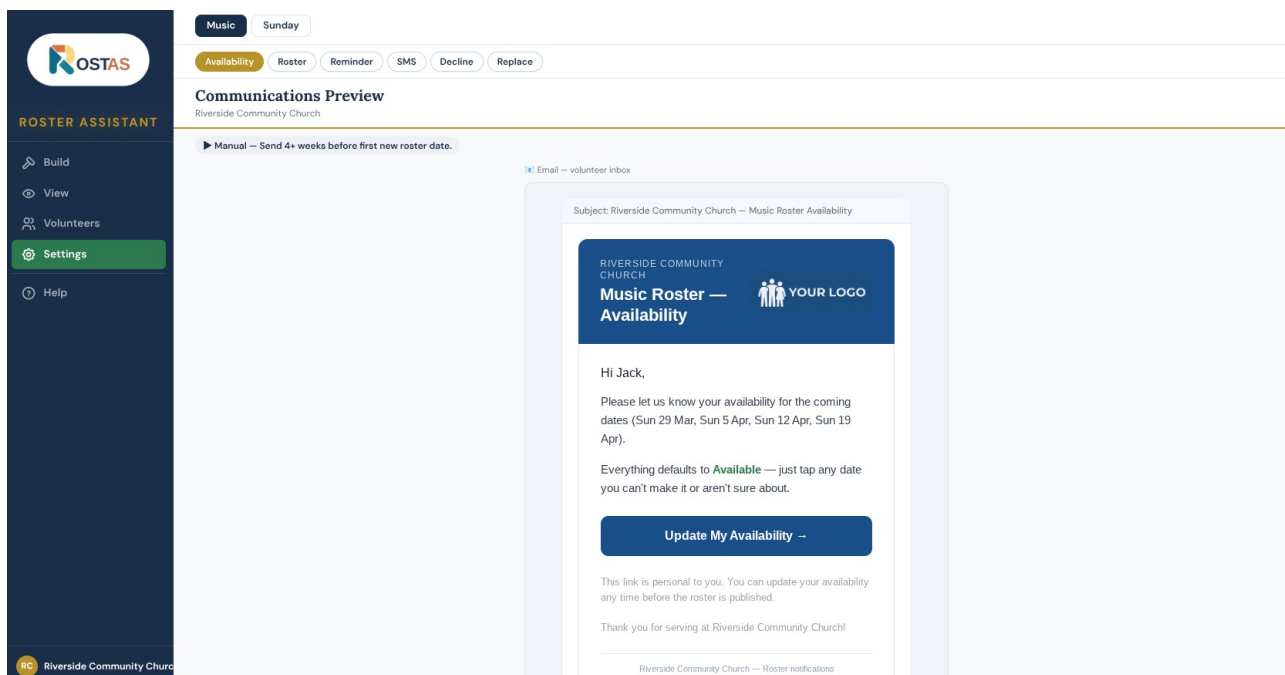
Unfilled

Assign volunteer

Close

	Baking for Morning Tea	Barista Coffee	Door & Offering	Prayer Ministry	Serving Morning Tea
Sun 4 Apr 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 4 Apr	Priya Sharma Sun 4 Apr	Ben Nakamura Sun 4 Apr	Fiona Walsh Sun 4 Apr	David Chen Sun 4 Apr
Sun 11 Apr 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 11 Apr	Priya Sharma Sun 11 Apr	Ben Nakamura Sun 11 Apr	Fiona Walsh Sun 11 Apr	David Chen Sun 11 Apr
Sun 18 Apr 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 18 Apr	Priya Sharma Sun 18 Apr	Ben Nakamura Sun 18 Apr	Fiona Walsh Sun 18 Apr	David Chen Sun 18 Apr
Sun 25 Apr 2027 10/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 25 Apr	Priya Sharma Sun 25 Apr	Chloe Tanaka Sun 25 Apr	Ben Nakamura Sun 25 Apr	Fiona Walsh Sun 25 Apr
Sun 2 May 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 2 May	Priya Sharma Sun 2 May	Ben Nakamura Sun 2 May	Fiona Walsh Sun 2 May	David Chen Sun 2 May
Sun 9 May 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 9 May	Priya Sharma Sun 9 May	Ben Nakamura Sun 9 May	Fiona Walsh Sun 9 May	David Chen Sun 9 May
Sun 16 May 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 16 May	Priya Sharma Sun 16 May	Ben Nakamura Sun 16 May	Fiona Walsh Sun 16 May	David Chen Sun 16 May
Sun 23 May 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 23 May	Priya Sharma Sun 23 May	Ben Nakamura Sun 23 May	Fiona Walsh Sun 23 May	David Chen Sun 23 May

The Roster Board in review mode — click any cell to select it and access the action bar. Make any swaps needed, then return to the wizard when you're satisfied with the roster.

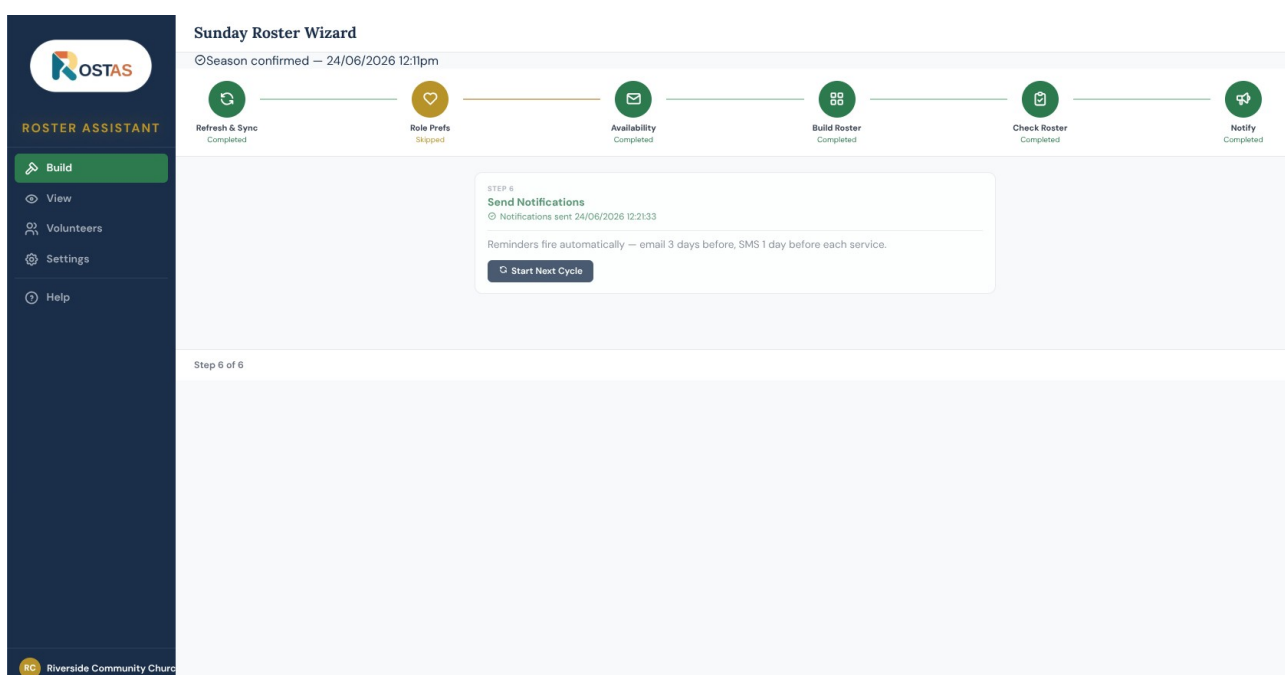


The Communications Preview — see exactly what each volunteer will receive. Check wording, names, roles, and dates before sending notifications.

Don't skip this step. It's your last chance to catch problems before volunteers are notified. Check for unfilled slots, confirm the message wording looks right, and make any manual swaps needed.

Step 6 — Notify

Once you're satisfied with the roster, click **Send Notifications Now**. Every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments and a "Can't make it?" link.



Step 6 complete — all six steps show green ticks. Notifications have been sent and automatic reminders are queued. Click "Start Next Cycle" when you're ready to begin the next build.

- Email reminder sent 3 days before each service date
- SMS reminder sent 1 day before each service date
- If a volunteer taps "Can't make it" — the SMS replacement chain starts automatically

Confirming a New Season

When the current season is coming to an end, the Build Dashboard shows a **Season Confirm** button on the relevant roster card. You need to confirm the next season's dates before you can run a new build.

Sunday Roster Wizard

Confirm New Season
Review the projected dates, set the season name, then confirm to create the season.

SEASON NAME
Sunday_Build_2_Apr_2027

START DATE: 04/04/2027 END DATE: 06/06/2027

PROJECTED DATES
04/04/2027 × 11/04/2027 × 18/04/2027 × 25/04/2027 × 02/05/2027 × 09/05/2027 × 16/05/2027 × 23/05/2027 × 30/05/2027 × 06/06/2027 ×

dd/mm/yyyy e.g. Xmas Party + Add

Confirm Season

Roles for this season

- **Rename** — applies from your next roster build. Already-built roster dates keep their original wording.
- **Headcount & Active/Inactive** changes apply from your next roster build onward — nothing already built changes.
- **Adding a role** also applies from your next roster build onward.

ROLE	HEADCOUNT		ACTIVE / INACTIVE
	MIN	MAX	
Baking for Morning Tea	3	3	Active
Barista Coffee	1	1	Active
Door & Offering	2	2	Active
Prayer Ministry			Active

The Season Confirm screen — review the proposed dates for the next season alongside the current roles list. Adjust dates if needed, then confirm. Rostas automatically pauses dates that fall on public or school holidays based on your roster settings.

To confirm a new season

Click the **Season Confirm** button on the Build Dashboard card. Review the proposed start and end dates, adjust if needed, then click **Confirm Season**. The roster card updates and you can proceed with a new build.

Confirm the season early — ideally a few weeks before the current season ends, so you have time to collect availability and build the next roster before the first date arrives.

The Roster Board is where you manage the roster between builds. You'll come here to check on replacement progress, make manual swaps, confirm pending assignments, or search for a specific volunteer. Access it by clicking **View** in the sidebar.

Reading the Board

The Board shows every roster date as a row, with roles as columns. Each cell shows the assigned volunteer's name and date. Colour coding tells you the status of each assignment at a glance.

	Baking for Morning Tea			Barista Coffee	Door & Offering		Prayer Ministry		Serving Morning Tea	
Sun 22 Aug 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 22 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 22 Aug	— Sun 22 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 22 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 22 Aug	David Chen Sun 22 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 22 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 22 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 22 Aug	Grace Kim Sun 22 Aug
Sun 29 Aug 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 29 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 29 Aug	— Sun 29 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 29 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 29 Aug	David Chen Sun 29 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 29 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 29 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 29 Aug	James Taufa Sun 29 Aug
Sun 5 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 5 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 5 Sep	— Sun 5 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 5 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 5 Sep	David Chen Sun 5 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 5 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 5 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 5 Sep	Grace Kim Sun 5 Sep
Sun 12 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 12 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 12 Sep	— Sun 12 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 12 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 12 Sep	David Chen Sun 12 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 12 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 12 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 12 Sep	James Taufa Sun 12 Sep
Sun 19 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 19 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 19 Sep	— Sun 19 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 19 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 19 Sep	David Chen Sun 19 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 19 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 19 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 19 Sep	Grace Kim Sun 19 Sep
Sun 26 Sep 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 26 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 26 Sep	— Sun 26 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 26 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 26 Sep	David Chen Sun 26 Sep	Mark Sullivan Sun 26 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 26 Sep	Chris Parata Sun 26 Sep	James Taufa Sun 26 Sep
Sun 3 Oct 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 3 Oct	Priya Sharma Sun 3 Oct	— Sun 3 Oct	Ben Nakamura Sun 3 Oct	Fiona Walsh Sun 3 Oct	David Chen Sun 3 Oct	Mark Sullivan Sun 3 Oct	Daniel Ferreira Sun 3 Oct	Chris Parata Sun 3 Oct	Grace Kim Sun 3 Oct
Sun 10 Oct 2027 9/10	Lisa Ngatai Sun 10 Oct	Priya Sharma Sun 10 Oct	— Sun 10 Oct	Ben Nakamura Sun 10 Oct	Fiona Walsh Sun 10 Oct	David Chen Sun 10 Oct	Mark Sullivan Sun 10 Oct	Daniel Ferreira Sun 10 Oct	Chris Parata Sun 10 Oct	James Taufa Sun 10 Oct

The Roster Board — dates run down the left, role columns across the top with green headers. Use the roster type tabs at the very top to switch between rosters. The legend and frequency search are in the header row above the grid.

Legend and Frequency

The legend row at the top of the board shows the four cell states. To the right, the **volunteer search** (with ◀▶ navigation arrows) lets you find a specific person and step through volunteers one by one. The **Frequency** panel shows how often the currently searched volunteer is rostered and when they were last assigned.

Taking Action on a Cell

Click any cell on the board to select it. The selected cell gets a navy border and a sticky action bar appears across the full width of the page — showing the volunteer's name, role, date, and current status, with action buttons on the right.

The screenshot displays the Roster Assistant interface for a Sunday Roster Board. The interface includes a sidebar with navigation options: Build, View (selected), Volunteers, Settings, and Help. The main area shows a grid of roles and their assigned volunteers. A sticky action bar is visible at the top, displaying the selected cell's details: Sarah Mitchell, Prayer Ministry, 19/07/2026, and Filled status. The board grid shows various roles like Baking for Morning Tea, Barista Coffee, Door & Offering, Prayer Ministry, and Serving Morning Tea, with assigned volunteers listed in each cell.

Role	Volunteer	Date	Status
Baking for Morning Tea	Emma Larsen	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Baking for Morning Tea	Lisa Ngatai	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Baking for Morning Tea	Amy Thornton	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Barista Coffee	Grace Kim	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Door & Offering	Daniel Ferreira	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Door & Offering	David Chen	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Prayer Ministry	Sarah Mitchell	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Prayer Ministry	Mark Sullivan	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Serving Morning Tea	Rachel Osei	Sun 19 Jul	Filled
Serving Morning Tea	Chris Parata	Sun 19 Jul	Filled

Clicking a cell opens the sticky action bar across the top, showing who is assigned, their role, date, and status. The available replacements panel drops in below, listing tiered candidates with Select buttons. The board grid remains visible behind it.

Manual Replacement

When you click **Replace**, the replacement panel appears below the action bar showing all available volunteers for that role and date, sorted by priority tier. Each volunteer shows their availability status and how recently they've been rostered.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS Sunday Roster Board interface. At the top, there's a header with the ROSTAS logo, a 'Sunday' filter, and a 'Music' button. Below this is the 'Sunday Roster Board' section with tabs for 'Filled', 'SMS Chain', 'Pending', and 'Unfilled'. A search bar is on the right. The main area displays the 'Baking for Morning Tea' role for the date 16/05/2027. A replacement panel is open, showing a list of available replacements with their names, availability status, and a 'Select' button. Below the list is a grid of roles: Baking for Morning Tea, Barista Coffee, Door & Offering, Prayer Ministry, and Serving Morning Tea. Each role has a list of volunteers with their names and dates.

Role	Volunteer	Date
Baking for Morning Tea	Lisa Ngatai	Sun 4 Apr
Baking for Morning Tea	Priya Sharma	Sun 4 Apr
Baking for Morning Tea	—	Sun 4 Apr
Barista Coffee	Ben Nakamura	Sun 4 Apr
Door & Offering	Fiona Walsh	Sun 4 Apr
Prayer Ministry	Mark Sullivan	Sun 4 Apr
Serving Morning Tea	Chris Parata	Sun 4 Apr
Serving Morning Tea	Grace Kim	Sun 4 Apr

The replacement panel — volunteers are grouped by tier. Click Select next to any volunteer to assign them immediately. The original volunteer is released and the new one is notified automatically.

The tiers match the engine. Tier 1 volunteers are available and have this as a primary role — the ideal replacement. Lower tiers are less ideal but still valid options. Pick the best fit for the situation.

The replacement volunteer is notified automatically. Once you click Select, Rostas sends them an SMS and email with their assignment details. You don't need to contact them separately.

Assigning a Second Role on the Same Date

Occasionally a volunteer may need to cover two roles on the same date — for example, stepping in for a missing team member while also serving in their usual role. Rostas supports this but flags it clearly so you're making a deliberate choice rather than an accidental double-booking.

How to assign a second role

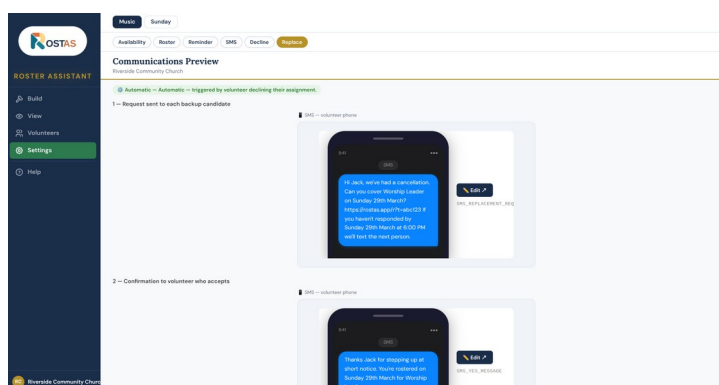
On the Volunteer detail page, navigate to the date in question. An amber collapsible section labelled **Second role — already rostered today** appears. Expand it to assign the additional role. The frequency cap counts this date only once regardless of how many roles are assigned on it.

Use this sparingly. Volunteers serving in multiple roles in one service can feel stretched. Always confirm with the volunteer before assigning a second role.

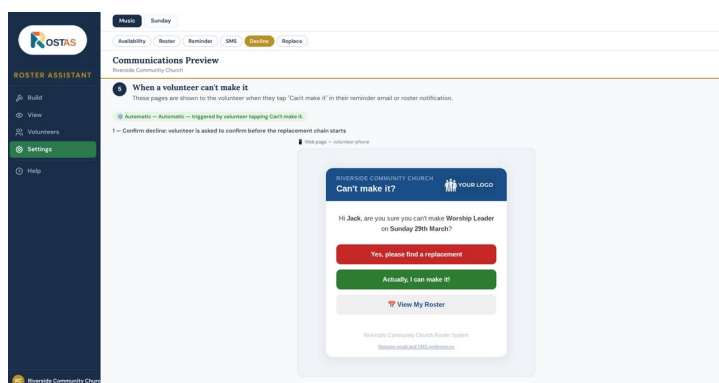
The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" in their notification email — or when you click **Save as declined** on the board — Rostas starts the automated SMS replacement chain. It works through available volunteers one at a time until someone accepts.

The request text carries a **4-digit code** rather than a link — NZ networks filter many link-bearing texts, and a code is shorter and cheaper to send. The volunteer enters it at **rostas.app/enter** to reach the accept / decline page. See Part A for the full explanation of code entry.



The replacement chain in action — the request SMS (left) carries a 4-digit code the volunteer enters at rostas.app/enter. Once they accept, a confirmation SMS is sent immediately (right).



The volunteer-facing decline page — when a volunteer taps "Can't make it", they see this page with two clear options. If they changed their mind they can immediately reinstate themselves.

Quiet hours apply to the SMS chain. Messages are never sent during your quiet hours (set in Settings → SMS, default 9pm–8am). If the chain reaches a volunteer inside that window it pauses automatically and resumes once quiet hours end. You can monitor progress on the board — cells in the SMS chain state show in blue.

Searching for a Volunteer

Use the search field at the top right of the board to find a specific volunteer. As you type, their assignments are highlighted across the entire board — making it easy to see all their upcoming dates at once. Use the ◀▶ arrows to step through volunteers alphabetically. The Frequency panel shows how often the current volunteer is rostered and when they last served.

Use volunteer search before making a manual replacement. Search for the volunteer you're thinking of replacing them with first — check they're not already heavily rostered that period before adding another date.

The Volunteers section is where you manage everyone who serves in your organisation. Access it by clicking **Volunteers** in the sidebar. From here you can view all volunteers, add new ones, edit details, and manage per-roster settings like role preferences, frequency caps, and availability.

The Volunteers List

The volunteers list shows every volunteer in the system — their name, roster types, phone number, and email at a glance. Use the search bar to find someone quickly, or filter by Active, Inactive, or All using the chips below the search bar.

The screenshot displays the ROSTAS interface for the 'Volunteers' list. On the left is a dark sidebar with the 'ROSTAS' logo and navigation links: Build, View, **Volunteers**, Settings, and Help. The main area has a header with 'Volunteers', 'Import Volunteer CSV', 'Add Volunteer', and a search bar. Below the header, filter chips show 'All' (30), 'Active' (30), 'Inactive' (0), and 'Needs review' (3). A table lists 15 volunteers with columns for NAME, ROSTER TYPES, PHONE, and EMAIL. Rows for Lisa Ngatai, Liam Fraser, and Grace Hohepa are highlighted in yellow, each with a 'Needs review' tag. Each row ends with a three-dot menu icon for more actions.

NAME	ROSTER TYPES	PHONE	EMAIL
James Taufa	Sunday, Music	6421000002	james@riverside.example.com
Emma Larsen	Sunday, Music	6421000003	emma@riverside.example.com
David Chen	Sunday, Music	6421000004	david@riverside.example.com
Tom Bradshaw	Sunday, Music	6421000006	tom@riverside.example.com
Lisa Ngatai	Sunday, Music	6421000007	lisa@riverside.example.com
Amy Thornton	Sunday, Music	6421000011	amy@riverside.example.com
Sarah Mitchell	Sunday, Music	6421345678	sarah.mitchell@email.com
James Taufa	Sunday, Music	6421456789	james.taufa@email.com
Emma Johansson	Sunday, Music	6421789012	emma.johansson@email.com
Liam Fraser	Music	6422234567	liam.fraser@email.com
Sophie Anderson	Sunday, Music	6422345678	sophie.anderson@email.com
Grace Hohepa	Music	6422567890	grace.hohepa@email.com
Ethan Blackwood	Sunday, Music	6422678901	ethan.blackwood@email.com
Chloe Tanaka	Sunday, Music	6422789012	chloe.tanaka@email.com

The Volunteers list — all volunteers in one place. Search by name, email, or phone. Click any row to open that volunteer's detail page.

Click any row to open the volunteer's full detail page — where you can edit their information, manage their roster preferences, set frequency caps, and view their availability history.

Adding a Volunteer

To add a new volunteer, click **Add Volunteer** in the top right of the Volunteers list. Fill in their details and save — they'll appear in the list immediately and can be included in your next roster build.

New volunteer details

FULL NAME *

MOBILE PHONE *

Local numbers are converted automatically e.g. 0211234567 → +64211234567

EMAIL

ROSTER TYPES *

☐ Sunday ☐ Music

Select at least one roster this volunteer will be part of

The Add Volunteer form — enter the volunteer's name, mobile number, email, and which roster types they serve in. Mobile must include the country code.

Mobile number format matters. Enter numbers in full international format including country code — e.g. +6421123456, not 021123456. Incorrectly formatted numbers will fail to receive SMS messages silently.

Importing Volunteers from CSV

If you have a spreadsheet of volunteers, use the CSV Import Wizard to bring them in all at once. Click **Import CSV** in the top right of the Volunteers list.

Import Volunteers

Preview 30 volunteers →

Upload Match columns Preview Duplicates Import

STEP 2 OF 5

Match your columns to Rostas fields

Rostas has read your file and suggested how each column maps. Review the picks below – change any that look wrong before continuing.

6 of 16 columns matched automatically
10 columns ignored.

YOUR COLUMN	MAPS TO ROSTAS FIELD	CONFIDENCE
Volunteer_ID VOL_T001, VOL_T002, VOL_T003	→ — Don't import	Ignored
Full_Name Sarah Mitchell, James Taufu, E...	→ Full name (combined)	Confident
Phone +646421000001, 6421000002, 642...	→ Mobile phone	Confident
Email sarah@riverside.example.com, j...	→ Email	Confident
Ministry_Pref Sunday, Sunday, Music, Sunday,...	→ Roster Type (Sunday / Music / Noi)	Confident
Is_Coordinator Yes	→ — Don't import	Ignored

The CSV column mapping step — Rostas automatically matches columns it recognises with a "Confident" badge. Review the remaining columns and map them manually before importing.

How to import from CSV

Go to **Volunteers → Import CSV**. Upload your spreadsheet file, then map each column to the correct Rostas field (name, mobile, email, roster type). Review the preview, then click Import. Any phone numbers that are missing the country code are automatically corrected during import.

Your CSV needs at minimum: Full name and mobile number. Email is strongly recommended. If your spreadsheet has a column for roster type or ministry preference, map it during import and volunteers will be automatically assigned to the right rosters.

Volunteer Detail Page

Click any volunteer in the list to open their detail page. This is where you manage everything about that volunteer — their contact details, which rosters they're in, role preferences, frequency caps, availability, and notes.

The screenshot shows the 'Volunteer Detail Page' for Sarah Mitchell. On the left is a dark blue sidebar with the 'OSTAS' logo and 'ROSTER ASSISTANT' title. It contains navigation links: 'Build', 'View', 'Volunteers' (highlighted), 'Settings', and 'Help'. Below these is the 'Riverside Community Church' logo. The main content area is light gray. At the top, it shows '23 of 27 · Sunday' and a 'Save Sunday settings' button. The volunteer's profile card on the left includes a circular avatar with 'SM', the name 'Sarah Mitchell', phone '+646421000001', and email 'sarah@riverside.example.com'. It has three toggles for 'Active', 'Email', and 'SMS', all set to 'On'. Below are 'ROSTER TYPES' (Sunday, Music) and a 'NOTES' section with a text area and an 'Edit contact details' button. The right panel shows '23 of 27 · Sunday' and tabs for 'Sunday' and 'Music'. It features a 'ROLES' section with 'Does This', 'Fills In', and 'Doesn't Do' buttons, and a list of roles: 'Baking for Morning Tea', 'Barista Coffee', 'Door & Offering', 'Prayer Ministry', and 'Serving Morning Tea'. Below is a 'FREQUENCY - ONCE EVERY:' section with buttons for '2wk', '3wk', '4wk' (selected), '6wk', '8wk', '12wk', and 'No cap'. To the right is a 'RELATIONAL ROSTERING' section with 'Buddy' and 'Household' tabs, and 'Serves With' buttons set to 'Off'. At the bottom, there's a 'NEXT ROSTER AVAILABILITY' section showing 'No upcoming dates yet.' and a 'NOTES' section with a text area.

The Volunteer detail page — contact details and roster type tabs on the left, roster-specific settings on the right. Use the roster type tabs to switch between rosters the volunteer serves in.

Contact Details and Toggles

The left panel shows the volunteer's name, phone, email, and active status. Three toggles control their participation:

Roster Settings

The right panel shows settings for the currently selected roster type. Use the roster type tabs at the top of the left panel to switch between rosters if the volunteer serves in more than one.

The right panel for the Music roster — roles with legend pills showing Primary/Fillable/Not for me, frequency cap, buddy preference, and household rostering settings. Each roster type has its own independent settings.

Adding a Volunteer to a New Roster

If a volunteer starts serving in an additional roster type, click the inactive roster tab on their detail page. A confirmation dialog appears — confirm to add them to that roster. Their settings for the new roster start fresh and can be configured from the right panel.

Clicking an inactive roster tab shows a confirmation before adding the volunteer. Once confirmed they appear in that roster's volunteer pool at the next build.

What Volunteers See

Volunteers interact with Rostas entirely through personalised links sent by email or SMS — no login, no app to download. There are three volunteer-facing pages:

Riverside Community Church

YOUR UPCOMING ROSTER



YOUR LOGO

Dear Jack,

Thank you for your willingness to serve at [OrgName]. Here are your upcoming roster assignments:

Sunday, 29 March 2026

☒ **You're Rostered On**

Door & Offering

☒ **Can't make it**

Sunday, 5 April 2026

☐ **Can you make it?**

Baking for Morning Tea

☒ **Yes, I can make it**

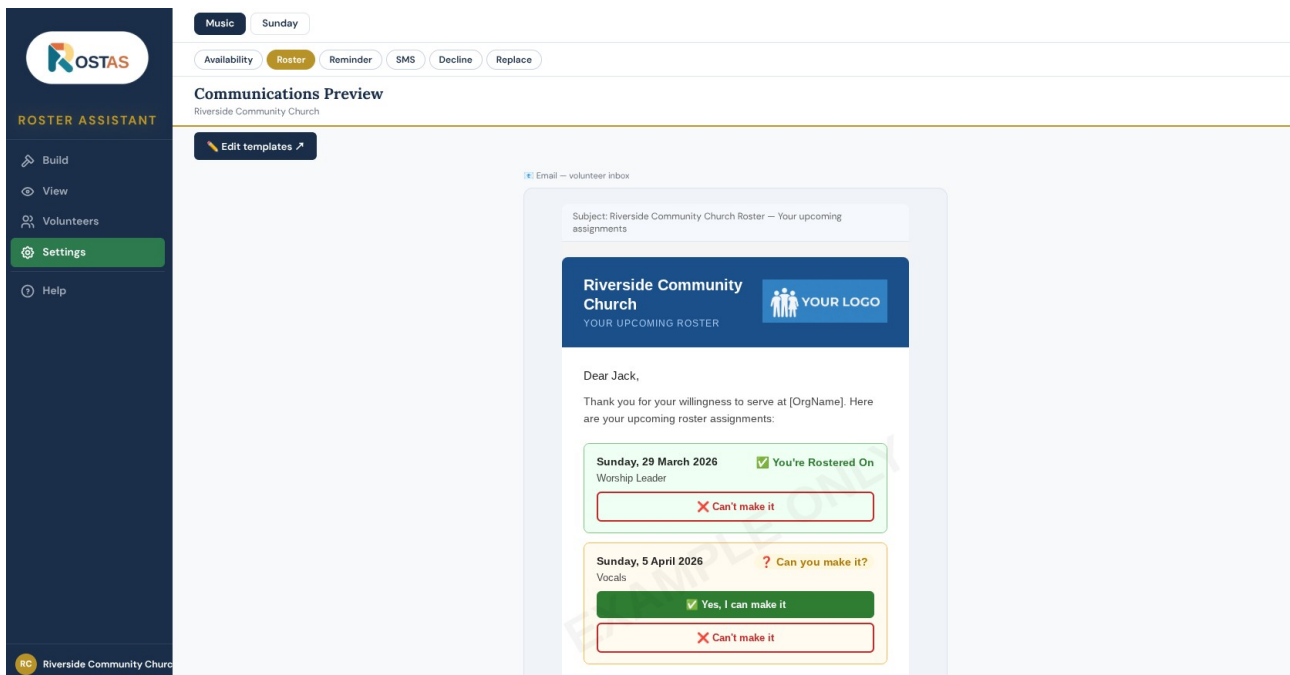
☒ **Can't make it**

Please plan to arrive a few minutes early so everything is ready before the service begins. If you have any questions, get in touch with **Sarah Mitchell** at coordinator@knoxwaitara.org.nz.



View My Roster

The volunteer roster view — shows upcoming assignments in a clean mobile-friendly layout. Volunteers access this via the link in their notification email.



The roster notification email — every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments. The "Can't make it?" button at the bottom starts the replacement chain if tapped.

All volunteer pages are mobile-optimised. Most volunteers will open them on their phone directly from an email or SMS. No app installation, no account creation — just a tap.

The Settings view is where you configure how Rostas behaves — your organisation's identity, SMS credentials, message wording, timing rules, and more. Open it by clicking **Settings** in the left sidebar.

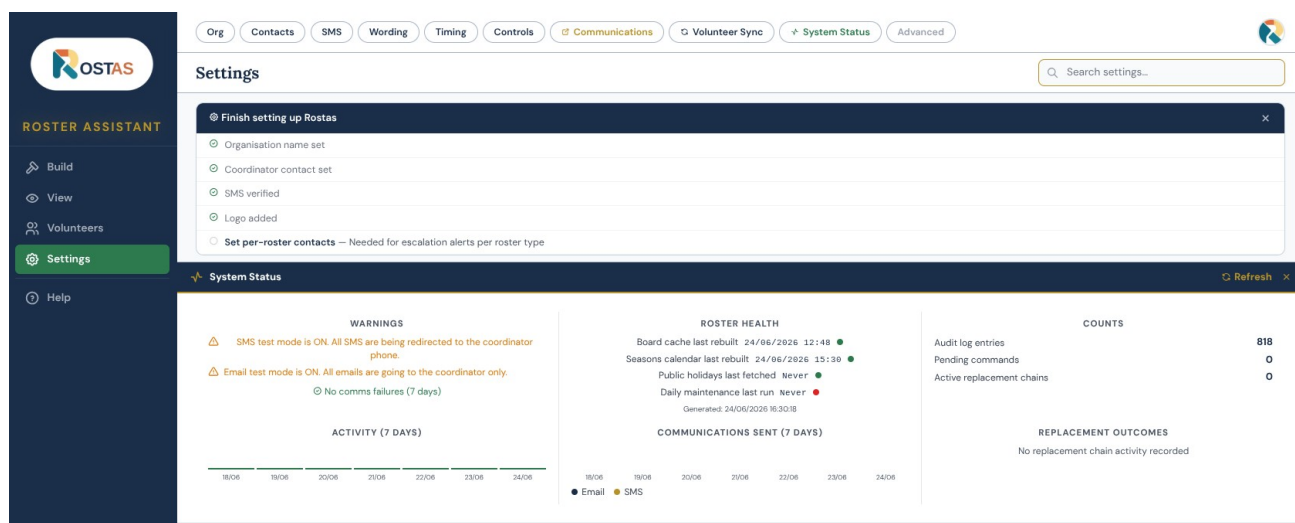
The Settings View

Finding your way around

The Settings view has two parts that work together.

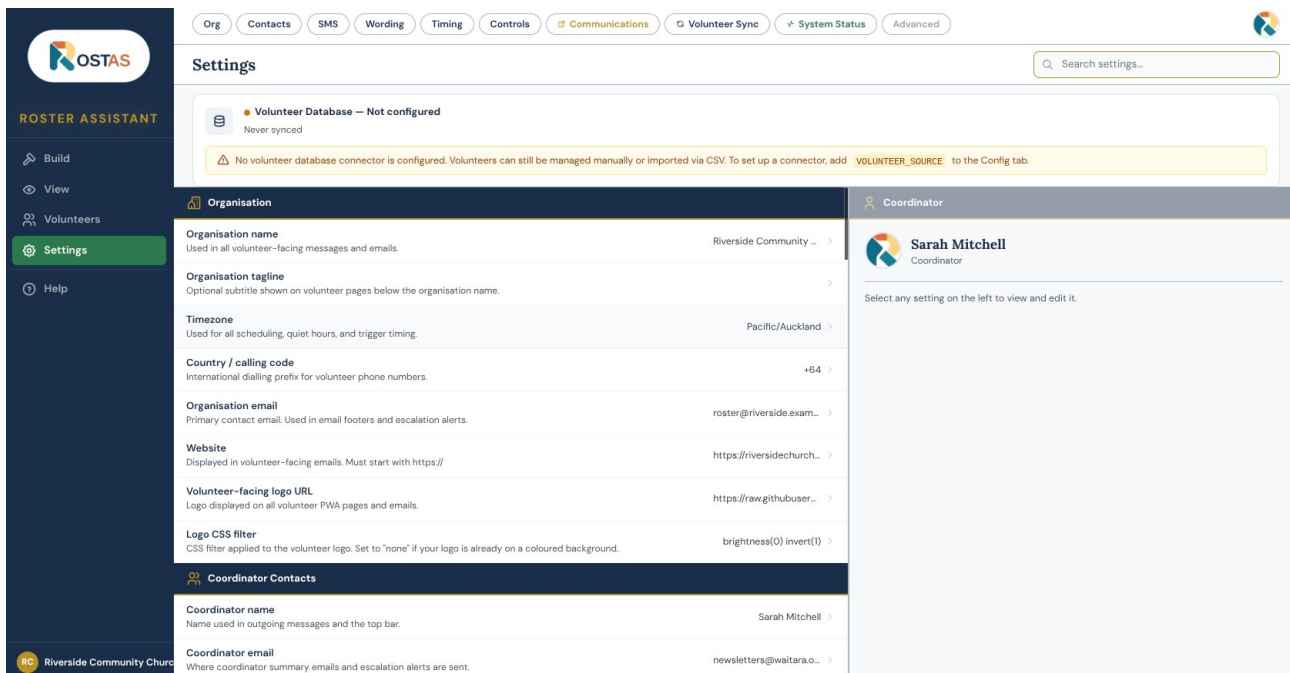
The **chip strip** runs across the top and lets you jump directly to any category — Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, System Status, and Advanced. Clicking a chip scrolls the left panel to that section instantly. The **Communications** chip (gold, with an arrow) opens the Communications Preview in place of Settings — use it to see how your message templates look before sending.

The **search bar** (top right, "Search settings...") filters the left panel live as you type. It searches across setting names and descriptions simultaneously — so typing "SMS" shows not just the SMS category but any setting whose description mentions SMS, across all categories. Non-matching rows disappear; categories with no matches collapse. Clear the search to restore the full list.



The chip strip across the top of Settings — click any category pill to jump straight to that section. The gold Communications chip opens the message preview. The System Status panel is visible at the top of the left panel.

The two-column layout

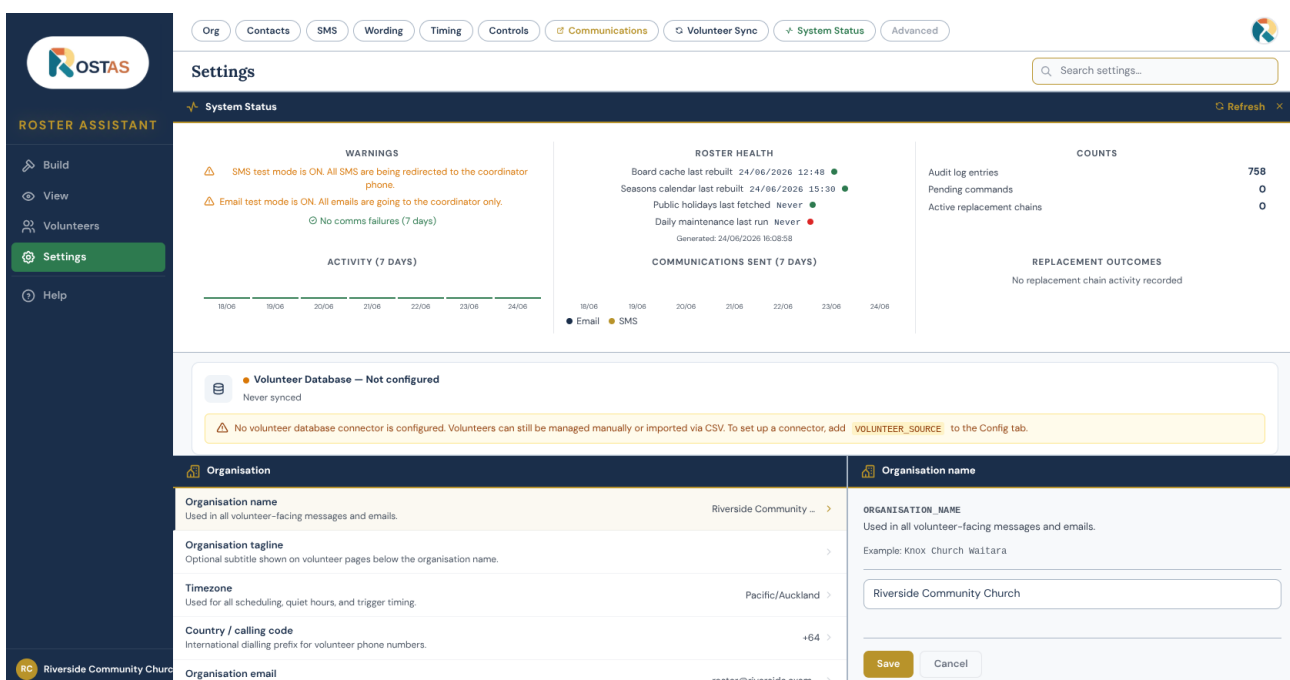


The two-column layout — categories and settings in the scrollable left panel, the selected setting's detail and edit field in the sticky right panel.

- **Left panel** — the scrollable list of all settings, grouped by category. Each row shows the setting name, a one-line description, and its current value on the right. Click any row to open it for editing.
- **Right panel** — appears when you click a row. Shows the full description, an example value, the input field, and Save/Cancel buttons. The panel stays fixed while you scroll the left panel, so you can read and compare other settings without losing your place.

To close the right panel without saving, click Cancel or click a different row.

Editing a setting



The right panel — key name at top, friendly label, full description, example value, and the input field. Validation runs as you type. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.

1. Click the row in the left panel. The right panel opens showing the setting name, description, and current value pre-filled in the input.
2. Make your change. The input type matches the setting — dropdowns for timezone and country code, toggles for on/off settings, text fields for everything else.
3. Validation runs as you type or on blur. If the value is invalid (wrong format, missing required content) the field turns red with an explanation. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.
4. Click **Save**. The left panel updates immediately to show the new value — no page reload needed.

Using System Status

The System Status card and the settings list below it are designed to work together. The card tells you what's wrong; the settings list is where you fix it.

Treat System Status as your starting point every time you open the Settings page. Before searching for a specific setting or making a planned change, glance at the Warnings column first. If it shows green — "All systems go" — you can proceed. If it shows amber or red, deal with those first, because some warnings mean volunteers aren't receiving messages right now.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS Settings page. At the top, there's a navigation bar with tabs: Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, Communications (selected), Volunteer Sync, System Status, and Advanced. Below this is the 'Settings' header with a search bar. The main content area is divided into two sections. The top section is 'System Status', which contains three columns: 'WARNINGS', 'ROSTER HEALTH', and 'COUNTS'. The 'WARNINGS' column shows two warnings: 'SMS test mode is ON. All SMS are being redirected to the coordinator phone.' and 'Email test mode is ON. All emails are going to the coordinator only.' The 'ROSTER HEALTH' column shows various indicators like 'Board cache last rebuilt', 'Seasons calendar last rebuilt', 'Public holidays last fetched', and 'Daily maintenance last run'. The 'COUNTS' column shows 'Audit log entries' (758), 'Pending commands' (0), and 'Active replacement chains' (0). Below these columns is an 'ACTIVITY (7 DAYS)' sparkline chart. The bottom section is 'Organisation', which contains fields for 'Organisation name', 'Organisation tagline', 'Timezone', 'Country / calling code', and 'Organisation email'. To the right of the Organisation section is the 'Coordinator' section, which shows the name 'Sarah Mitchell' and a 'Select any setting on the left to view and edit it.' message.

The System Status panel — three columns showing current warnings, roster health indicators, and message counts. Check this panel if volunteers aren't receiving messages or something seems off.

Following a warning to its fix

Every warning in the System Status card maps directly to one or more settings in the list below. Rather than hunting through categories manually, use the search bar — the warning text itself usually contains the keyword you need:

The typical workflow is: see the warning → type the keyword into the search bar → click the matching row → fix it in the right panel → save. The whole thing takes under a minute once you know the pattern.

After making a change, check the card again

The System Status card doesn't update automatically when you save a setting — it loaded when you opened Settings and reflects that moment in time. After fixing a warning, click **Refresh** in the System Status card header to reload it and confirm the warning has cleared.

Understanding your roster's rhythm

Once warnings are clear, the lower sections of the card give you a different kind of visibility — not problems to fix, but patterns to understand.

- **Activity sparkline** — tells you whether Rostas is actually doing things day-to-day. A healthy system shows green bars most days. A flat line across the past week may mean the daily triggers have stopped running.

- **Communications Sent chart** — shows whether emails and SMS are actually going out. If you sent availability emails three days ago but the chart shows zero emails on that date, check whether email test mode was on at the time.
- **Replacement Outcomes bar** — useful after your first few roster cycles. A high timeout rate often means your replacement timers are too short for how quickly your volunteers respond, or that quiet hours are eating into available sending time.
- **Communication Failures table** — the most direct diagnostic tool. If a volunteer tells you they never received a replacement SMS, check this table for an ERROR entry on the date in question. If you see nothing at all for that date, the message may have been suppressed before sending — check SMS enabled, test mode, and quiet hours.

A coordinator who builds this habit — open Settings, check System Status, fix any warnings, then do what you came to do — will catch problems before volunteers notice them rather than after.

Settings Categories

- **Organisation** — your organisation's name, tagline, timezone, country calling code, contact email, website, and volunteer-facing logo. The organisation name is the most important field: it appears in every SMS and email sent to volunteers as [OrgName]. Get this right first.
- **Coordinator Contacts** — your name, email, and mobile, plus per-roster coordinator contacts for Sunday, Music, Nourish, and any other roster types you've added. The per-roster contacts receive escalation alerts when a replacement chain is exhausted with no one found.
- **SMS** — the SMS kill switch, test mode toggle, quiet hours, replacement timers, and Twilio credentials. See SMS settings in detail below.
- **Message Wording** — every SMS template and email text block that Rostas sends to volunteers. SMS templates show a live character counter and required placeholder checker. See Message wording below.
- **Timing & Behaviour** — how many weeks ahead to build rosters, freeze weeks, availability form deadline, reminder timing, and public holiday region. The **Public holidays region** field includes a dropdown of supported countries and a "Fetch holidays now" button — use this to pull the latest public holidays for your country whenever you update this setting.
- **Quick Controls** — per-roster active toggles and email test mode. Useful for temporarily hiding a roster from the Build wizard without deleting it, or for switching email test mode on and off quickly.
- **Advanced** — settings that affect system internals (web app URL, roster type list, Twilio credentials). These are locked by default. Click Unlock to edit in the right panel and read the warning carefully before changing anything here. Incorrect values can stop roster builds or break SMS links. Contact tech support if unsure.

SMS Settings in Detail

Three settings here are worth understanding before you go live.

SMS enabled — the master kill switch. When this is false, no SMS leaves Rostas at all — not replacements, not reminders, not test sends. The System Status card shows a red warning when this is off. Only disable it deliberately (e.g. during a migration or if your Twilio account lapses).

SMS test mode — when true, every SMS that would go to a volunteer is redirected to the coordinator mobile instead. The message is prefixed with [TEST - would go to candidate]. Use this while setting up or testing replacement chains. Turn it off before your first real roster cycle. The System Status card shows an amber warning when test mode is on.

Quiet hours — SMS quiet hours start and end are set as 24-hour values (e.g. 21 = 9pm, 8 = 8am). Rostas will not send any SMS outside this window, including replacement chain advances. If a replacement request hits quiet hours, it waits until the quiet period ends before texting the next candidate. The default is 9pm–8am.

Replacement timers — three escalation speeds:

- **Normal** (default 120 min) — used when the service is more than 24 hours away
- **Urgent** (default 30 min) — used when the service is within 24 hours
- **Panic** (default 10 min) — used when the service is within 2 hours

If volunteers are frequently timing out before responding, consider increasing the normal timer. If you're often scrambling at short notice, reducing the urgent or panic timers gets through the candidate list faster.

Message Wording

Every SMS template has three protections built in to prevent accidental breakage.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS Settings interface. At the top, there's a navigation bar with tabs: Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, Communications (selected), Volunteer Sync, System Status, and Advanced. Below this is a 'Settings' header with a search bar. A warning message states: 'Volunteer Database — Not configured. Never synced. No volunteer database connector is configured. Volunteers can still be managed manually or imported via CSV. To set up a connector, add VOLUNTEER_SOURCE to the Config tab.' The main content area is divided into two panels. The left panel, titled 'Message Wording', lists various SMS templates with their descriptions and preview snippets. The right panel, titled 'Original volunteer released SMS', shows the 'SMS_TEMPLATE_RELEASE' template. It includes a character counter (105 / 160), a 'Preview SMS' button, and a 'Save' button that is disabled. A warning message indicates that SMS messages must stay under 160 characters. Below the template text, there are radio buttons for 'Music' and 'Sunday'.

Message Wording	Original volunteer released SMS
Replacement request SMS Sent when a volunteer cancels and Rostas needs a replacement. Hi [Name], we've had a ...	SMS_TEMPLATE_RELEASE Sent to the original volunteer when their slot is covered. Example: Hi [Name], no problem at all — we have found a replacement.
Replacement confirmed SMS Sent to the replacement volunteer when they accept. Great, thanks [Name] ...	SMS messages must stay under 160 characters. Longer messages are split and charged as two texts.
Original volunteer released SMS Sent to the original volunteer when their slot is covered. Hi [Name], no problem ...	Hi [Name], no problem at all — we have found a replacement for [Role] on [Date] — [OrgName] Roster Team.
Chain exhausted alert SMS Sent to the coordinator when no replacement is found. ROSTER ALERT: No repl...	Required: ✓ [Name] 105 / 160
Manual replacement SMS Sent when a coordinator manually assigns a replacement via the Roster Board. Hi [Name], you've been...	Preview SMS
Cross-roster ask SMS Sent when coordinator asks a volunteer from a different roster to fill in. Hi [Name], we're lookin...	Save Cancel
Availability nudge SMS Sent to volunteers who haven't responded to the availability email. Hi [Name], just a remin...	See in Preview
Roster email subject Subject line of the roster notification email. Your [OrgName] Roster	Music Sunday
Email opening text Opening paragraph of the roster email. Use [Name] for volunteer's name. Hi [Name]\n\nYour [Or...	
Email intro (multi-week) Used in the multi-week roster email format. Thank you for your will...	
Email arrival note Optional note appended to each roster entry about arrival time.	

SMS template fields show a live character counter (105/160 in this example), the required placeholder list, and a Preview SMS button. The Save button is disabled if the message exceeds 160 characters or is missing a required placeholder.

- **Character counter** — SMS messages over 160 characters are split into two by carriers and charged as two texts. The counter below the textarea turns amber at 140 characters and red at 161+. The Save button is disabled when the count is red. The SMS templates are deliberately terse for this reason — when you edit one, the counter is protecting your church's SMS costs, not just formatting.
- **Required placeholders** — each template has a set of placeholders that must be present for it to work correctly. For example, the replacement request SMS must include [Code] — without it, the volunteer has no code to enter. (The equivalent email templates require [Link] instead.) Missing placeholders are shown in red below the textarea. Save is blocked until all required placeholders are present.
- **Preview SMS** — click this button to see the template rendered with realistic sample values substituted in ([Name] → Sarah, [Role] → Welcome Team, [Date] → today's date, [Code] → a sample 4-digit code such as 4821). This shows you exactly what a volunteer will read, at the correct character count. It does not send a real SMS.

All placeholder names use square brackets: [Name], [Role], [Date], [Link], [Code], [OrgName], [Deadline]. Never use curly braces — {name} will not be substituted.

Template Placeholders

SMS and email templates use placeholders in square brackets that Rostas replaces with real values when sending. Never remove a required placeholder — if a required one is missing, the Save button is blocked.

Quick Controls

Quick Controls contains the most commonly needed on/off switches. Check these if something isn't behaving as expected.

The screenshot displays the 'Quick Controls' interface for SMS settings. It is divided into two main panels. The left panel, titled 'SMS', contains a list of settings: 'SMS enabled' (true), 'SMS test mode' (True), 'SMS quiet hours — start' (9:00 PM), 'SMS quiet hours — end' (8), 'Replacement timer — normal (minutes)' (120), 'Replacement timer — urgent (minutes)' (30), 'Replacement timer — panic (minutes)' (10), 'Twilio Account SID' (masked), 'Twilio Auth Token' (masked), and 'Twilio from number' (masked). The right panel, titled 'SMS enabled', shows a detailed view of the 'SMS_ENABLED' setting, which is currently turned on (indicated by a green toggle switch). Below the toggle are 'Save' and 'Cancel' buttons. The bottom of the interface has a 'Message Wording' tab.

Toggle fields in the right panel — a single switch with immediate visual feedback. The current state is always visible in the left panel list before you even click the row.

Always check test modes are OFF before sending a real roster. If `SMS_TEST_MODE` or `EMAIL_TEST_MODE` is True, volunteers will not receive any messages — only you will.

Advanced Settings

The Advanced section is collapsed by default and greyed out. It contains settings that the system needs to function but that coordinators rarely need to touch. Changing them incorrectly can cause roster builds to fail or SMS links to break.

To edit an advanced setting: click the row, read the amber warning in the right panel, then click **Unlock to edit**. The field becomes editable. Save as normal.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS Settings interface. The 'Advanced' tab is selected in the top navigation bar. The left sidebar shows 'Settings' as the active menu item. The main content area is divided into two panels. The left panel, titled 'Quick Controls', lists settings like 'Sunday roster active', 'Music roster active', 'Nourish roster active', and 'Email test mode'. The 'Nourish roster active' row is highlighted in yellow. Below this is a section titled 'Advanced' with a lock icon, containing settings like 'Web app URL', 'Roster types', 'Infodile site code', 'Infodile client ID', 'Infodile client secret', 'Infodile group IDs', and 'Infodile group map'. The right panel, titled 'Nourish roster active', shows the 'Roster ACTIVE_Nourish' setting with a description and an 'Off' toggle switch. At the bottom of the right panel are 'Save' and 'Cancel' buttons.

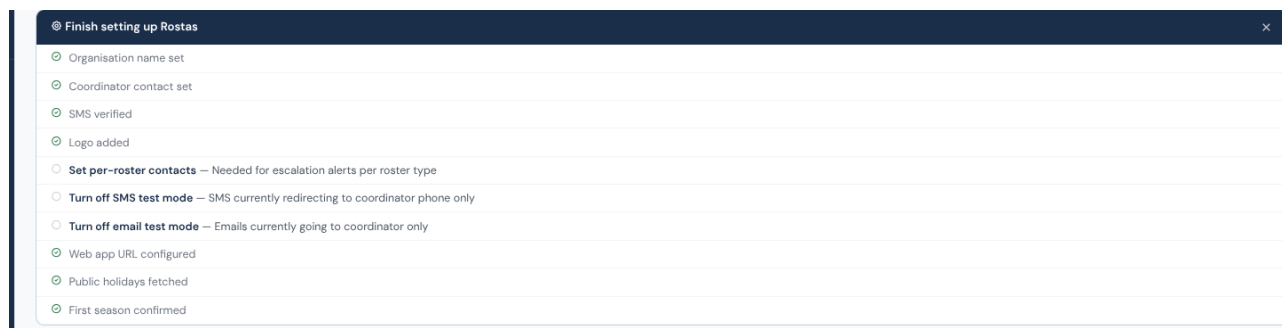
Advanced settings are collapsed by default and each row shows a lock icon. Click "Unlock to edit" in the right panel to make changes — only do this if you're confident about what you're changing.

The most common reason a coordinator needs the Advanced section is after redeploying Rostas — the **Web app URL** must be updated to match the new deployment URL. If short links in SMS stop working after a redeployment, this is almost always the cause.

Advanced settings can break things if changed incorrectly. If you're unsure, leave them as they are or contact your tech support person before making changes.

Setup Checklist

After the initial setup wizard completes, a checklist card appears at the top of the Settings view. It shows which setup tasks are done and which still need attention before going live. The checklist covers ten items — click any incomplete item to jump straight to the relevant setting.



The setup checklist — ticked items are confirmed complete by reading the current Config values, open circles need attention. Click any item to open the relevant setting. Dismiss the checklist once all ten items are ticked.

The checklist stays visible until you dismiss it. Once all ten items are ticked, click Dismiss to clear it. It won't appear again. If you dismiss it with items still incomplete, you can still fix them through the normal settings list — the checklist is a guide, not a gate.

Troubleshooting

Most issues in Rostas fall into a small number of categories. Work through this list before contacting tech support.

Volunteers aren't receiving SMS messages

- Check **Settings** → **Quick Controls** → **SMS_ENABLED** is True
- Check **SMS_TEST_MODE** is False — if True, all messages go to the coordinator only
- Check the volunteer's SMS toggle is On in their detail page
- Check quiet hours — SMS won't send between 9pm and 8am
- Check the volunteer's mobile number is in correct international format (+64...)
- Check the System Status communication failures table for error messages on the relevant date

Volunteers aren't receiving emails

- Check **EMAIL_TEST_MODE** is False in Quick Controls
- Check the volunteer's Email toggle is On in their detail page
- Ask the volunteer to check their spam/junk folder
- Confirm their email address is correct in their volunteer detail page

Roster has unfilled slots after building

- Check that enough volunteers have responded to the availability email
- Check that volunteers have role preferences set — without preferences set, the engine can't assign them to specific roles
- Check frequency caps — volunteers who've hit their monthly cap won't be assigned further
- Consider rebuilding after more availability responses come in
- Use manual replacement on the Board to fill remaining slots

SMS replacement chain isn't progressing

- Check quiet hours — chain pauses between 9pm and 8am and resumes automatically
- Check **SMS_ENABLED** is True
- Check there are eligible volunteers left on the backup list — if the list is exhausted you'll receive an escalation SMS
- Use manual replacement on the Board to assign someone directly

When to contact tech support

Contact your tech support person if:

- SMS messages are failing with error messages in the System Status communication failures table
- The web app URL has changed and volunteer links are broken
- You need to change Twilio or other API credentials
- Something is producing repeated errors that don't resolve on their own
- You need to add or remove a roster type
- Anything requiring access to the Google Apps Script editor

When contacting tech support, include a description of what you were doing, what you expected to happen, and what actually happened. A screenshot

of any error message or the System Status panel is very helpful.

Rostas Coordinator Guide · June 2026